Highlights

Information Lower Bounds of Trajectory Health Indicators for Remaining Useful Life Prediction

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- An information lower bound shows how much a health indicator retains about remaining life
- Monotonicity agrees with information on engines but not reliably on cells
- Static scalar indicators raise error by up to 18%; provide level and velocity
- Informative indicators reduce unused life at fixed failure risk by 23 to 45% on engines
- Ignoring operating regime or protocol raises estimation error by 8 to 26%

Information Lower Bounds of Trajectory Health Indicators for Remaining Useful Life Prediction

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Abstract

Health indicators (HIs) for remaining useful life (RUL) prediction are often selected by monotonicity-type scores or predictor accuracy, without measuring the information about the RUL that an HI retains. We bound the mean squared error of any HI-based RUL predictor below by the entropy power of the RUL given the HI; any predictor's held-out error lower-bounds, in nats, the information the HI retains beyond the age, and 0.1 nat lowers the bound on the root mean squared error (RMSE) by about 10 percent. Template shrinkage raises monotonicity while information falls; a static scalar HI increases the bound as the optimal weights change direction over the life; regime-blind estimators have an error floor; integrating encoders accumulate error unless corrected by observations. On turbofan engines and lithium-ion cells (77 to 260 units) the bound needs about 40 units and passes an age-only check except on one cell collection. Monotonicity-based scores agreed with the bound on engines, not reliably on cells; a static scalar HI increased RMSE up to 18 percent; ignoring regime or protocol raised estimation error 8 to 26 percent; informative HIs reduced unused life at fixed failure risk by 23 to 45 percent. No learned encoder outperformed simple HIs.

Keywords: information lower bound, health indicator, remaining useful life, information theory, information bottleneck, prognostics

1. Introduction

Prognostics and health management predicts the remaining useful life (RUL) of components such as batteries, bearings and aero-engines, and drives condition-based maintenance: when to replace a cell, schedule a bearing change or ground an engine [1–4]. Methods are conventionally divided into physics-based, data-driven and hybrid [3, 5], and recent work is dominated by deep networks that map sensor histories to the RUL end to end [6, 7]. An established alternative compresses the monitoring data into a scalar *health indicator* (HI) and extrapolates it to a failure threshold D_{fail}. An HI can be inspected by an engineer, the threshold gives the end of life (EOL) a physical meaning, and, when the HI is modelled as a stochastic process, the RUL is a first hitting time (FHT) with a known distribution [1, 8, 9]. Recent studies follow the same line [10–12], within the wider scope of reliability science [13, 14].

Three bodies of work bear on how an HI should be judged. First, HIs are usually selected by *geometric* criteria: Coble and Hines [15] formalised monotonicity, prognosability and trendability and optimised them with a genetic algorithm, and variants are

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common [16, 17]. HIs may also be learned by recurrent networks [18], autoencoders [19] or regressions on engineered features [20]; in both cases an HI is judged by its shape or by the accuracy of the predictor built on it [21]. Second, probabilistic RUL prediction from an HI is mostly built on Wiener degradation, whose first passage time is inverse Gaussian [22–24], with measurement error [8, 25], random unit-specific drift [26, 27], nonlinear drift [28] or threshold regression [9], applied to batteries [25] and bearings [29] (reviews: [1, 30]). The RUL uncertainty then has an aleatoric part (future randomness) and an epistemic part (incomplete knowledge of state and parameters) [31, 32], which deep ensembles are a common way to represent [33]. Third, information theory [34, 35] enters learning mainly through the information bottleneck [36–38]; estimating information from samples is difficult [39–42], and limits on estimator accuracy are usually stated through Cramér–Rao bounds [43–45], of which the entropy-power bound used here is the information-theoretic counterpart [35] (Remark 3).

Engineers who build an HI face five practical questions that these bodies of work do not answer. Does the HI retain the information that a predictor needs? Is a higher monotonicity score a better HI? Is one scalar enough, or are level and velocity both needed? Must operating regimes be modelled? Is a learned encoder, a neural network that maps the sensors to the HI, justified? In the sources we searched (bibliographic databases and the references above; this is not an exhaustive survey) we did not find a bound on the RUL error that depends on the HI only through the information it retains, nor an account of what a *scalar, static* indicator, a regime-blind estimator or an integrating encoder loses. A companion study [46] analysed what a static, per-snapshot projection of a multichannel signal retains about the degradation state. Here we analyse the HI *trajectory*, with its level, velocity, between-unit variability and operating regime. Two further studies by the authors address how many run-to-failure trajectories [47] and which charging-phase features [48] are needed; the present paper addresses how much *information* an HI can at best retain. Figure 1 shows the setting and where each result applies.

The paper answers these questions as follows.

1. **An information lower bound in nats** (Section 2). The entropy-power bound on the RUL error turns the held-out error of any predictor into a lower bound on the information that the HI retains beyond the age (Theorem 1). The bound is a transformation of the mean squared error: within one data set it ranks predictors exactly as the RMSE does, and the paper does not claim otherwise. It adds an absolute scale that is comparable across data sets (0.1 nat is an RMSE lower by about 10%), a negative control (a predictor that uses only the age cannot exceed zero, which shows whether the lifetime distribution behind the bound is valid) and, for Wiener degradation, a split of the error into an irreducible floor and a part that a better HI can remove (Section 3).
2. **Four ways in which an HI loses information** (Section 4): template shrinkage, projection on a static scalar, regime-blind estimation, and integration without observation correction. Each is stated as a result with its engineering consequence.
3. **Tests on real data and a benchmark** (Sections 5 and 6) on turbofan engines and lithium-ion cells, including the number of run-to-failure units that the bound requires, and a comparison of learned encoders with simple indicators.
4. **Engineering guidance** (Section 7): a decision table and a four-step workflow.

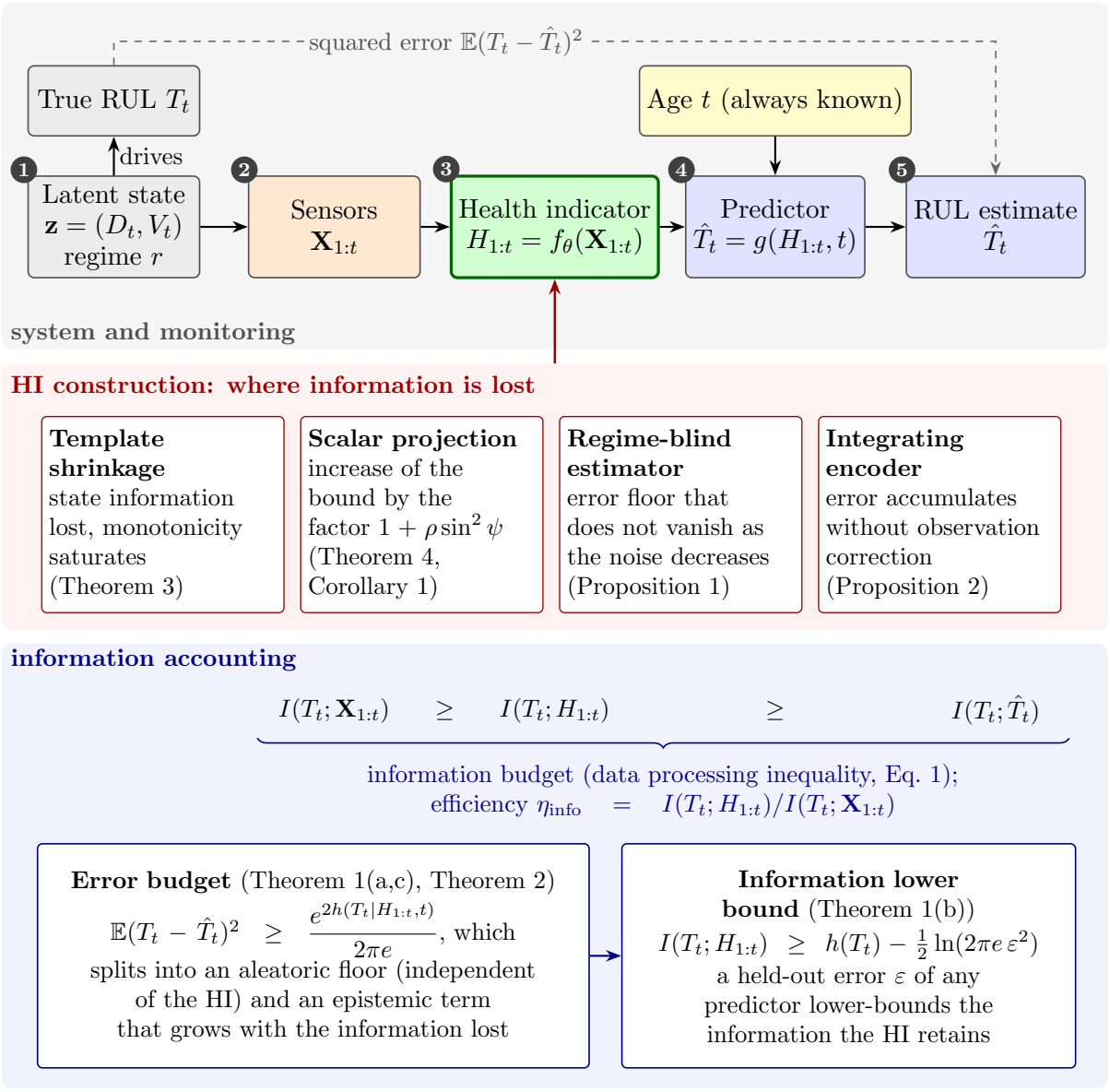


Figure 1: Framework of the paper. The HI is constructed from the sensors, which are driven by the same latent state as the true RUL, and the predictor uses the HI and the age. The data processing inequality gives an information budget; the red boxes list the operations of HI construction whose information loss is quantified.

The ingredients are classical: the data processing inequality, the chain rules, the maximum-entropy property of the Gaussian and the entropy-power bound [35]; the inverse-Gaussian distribution [23]; Gaussian conditioning [49]; the Kalman filter [50, 51]; and the variational bottleneck bound [37]. What is new is their use, with the age-only control, to measure the HI-construction step, the four losses that this explains, and the number of run-to-failure units that the measurement requires.

2. Information budget of a health indicator

Let $T_t > 0$ be the true RUL at inspection time (age) t, $\mathbf{X}_{1:t} \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times t}$ the accumulated history of d sensors, and $H_{1:t} = f_\theta(\mathbf{X}_{1:t})$ the HI trajectory produced by a map f_θ with parameters θ. Throughout, $h(\cdot)$ is differential entropy, $I(\cdot\,;\cdot)$ is mutual information (both

in nats), $\mathbb{E}$ and Var are expectation and variance, and $\mathcal{N}(\mu, \sigma^2)$ is the normal distribution. Any RUL estimator $\hat{T}_t = g(H_{1:t})$ obeys the Markov chain $T_t \to \mathbf{X}_{1:t} \to H_{1:t} \to \hat{T}_t$, because the latent degradation state drives both T_t and $\mathbf{X}_{1:t}$. The data processing inequality (DPI) [35, Sect. 2.8] gives

$$I(T_t; \mathbf{X}_{1:t}) \geq I(T_t; H_{1:t}) \geq I(T_t; \hat{T}_t), \tag{1}$$

with equality in the first inequality if and only if $H_{1:t}$ is a sufficient statistic of $\mathbf{X}_{1:t}$ for T_t [35, Sect. 2.9].

Theorem 1 (Information budget)**.** *Assume that $h(T_t)$ and $I(T_t; \mathbf{X}_{1:t})$ are finite, and let $\hat{T}_t$ be an estimator with finite second moment and mean squared error (MSE) $\varepsilon^2 = \mathbb{E}[(T_t - \hat{T}_t)^2]$. The information efficiency η_{info} below is defined when $I(T_t; \mathbf{X}_{1:t}) > 0$.*
(a) Bound. *If $\hat{T}_t = g(H_{1:t})$, then*

$$\varepsilon^2 \;\geq\; \mathcal{B}_{\text{info}}(H_{1:t}) := \frac{1}{2\pi e} \exp\big(2h(T_t \mid H_{1:t})\big) = \frac{1}{2\pi e} \exp\big(2h(T_t) - 2I(T_t; H_{1:t})\big), \tag{2}$$

$\mathcal{B}_{\text{info}}(H_{1:t}) \geq \mathcal{B}_{\min} := \frac{1}{2\pi e} e^{2h(T_t|\mathbf{X}_{1:t})}$, *and*

$$\mathcal{B}_{\text{info}}(H_{1:t})/\mathcal{B}_{\min} = \exp\big(2\,(1-\eta_{\text{info}}(H_{1:t}))\, I(T_t; \mathbf{X}_{1:t})\big), \qquad \eta_{\text{info}}(H_{1:t}) := \frac{I(T_t; H_{1:t})}{I(T_t; \mathbf{X}_{1:t})} \in [0, 1]. \tag{3}$$

(b) Information lower bound. *Such an estimator satisfies*

$$I(T_t; H_{1:t}) \;\geq\; h(T_t) - \tfrac{1}{2} \ln\big(2\pi e\, \varepsilon^2\big). \tag{4}$$

(c) Age. *The age t is always available to a predictor and is treated as a random variable over the inspection ages; $\mathbb{E}_t$ denotes the expectation over t and $h(T_t \mid t)$ the entropy of the conditional distribution of T_t given the age. If $\hat{T}_t = g(H_{1:t}, t)$, then $\varepsilon^2 \geq \frac{1}{2\pi e} \exp\big(2h(T_t \mid H_{1:t}, t)\big)$, and the information that the HI adds to the age satisfies*

$$I(T_t; H_{1:t}, t) = I(T_t; t) + I(T_t; H_{1:t} \mid t), \qquad I(T_t; H_{1:t} \mid t) \geq \mathbb{E}_t\, h(T_t \mid t) - \tfrac{1}{2} \ln\big(2\pi e\, \varepsilon^2\big). \tag{5}$$

Proof. (a) Let $E = T_t - g(H_{1:t})$. Differential entropy is translation invariant [35, Sect. 8.6], so $h(E \mid H_{1:t}) = h(T_t \mid H_{1:t})$ ($g(H_{1:t})$ is constant given $H_{1:t}$). Conditioning does not increase entropy [35, Sect. 2.6], so $h(E \mid H_{1:t}) \leq h(E)$, and the Gaussian maximises entropy at fixed second moment [35, Sect. 8.6], so $h(E) \leq \frac{1}{2} \ln(2\pi e\, \mathbb{E}[E^2])$. Combining the three relations gives $\mathbb{E}[E^2] \geq \frac{1}{2\pi e} e^{2h(T_t|H_{1:t})}$. The identity $h(T_t \mid H_{1:t}) = h(T_t) - I(T_t; H_{1:t})$ (definition of mutual information) gives the second form. By (1), $h(T_t \mid H_{1:t}) \geq h(T_t \mid \mathbf{X}_{1:t})$, and the ratio follows from $h(T_t \mid H_{1:t}) - h(T_t \mid \mathbf{X}_{1:t}) = I(T_t; \mathbf{X}_{1:t}) - I(T_t; H_{1:t})$. Applying the same steps conditionally on $H_{1:t} = \mathsf{h}$ and then averaging gives the sharper *pointwise* form $\varepsilon^2 \geq \mathbb{E}_H\big[e^{2h(T_t|H_{1:t}=\mathsf{h})}\big]/(2\pi e) \geq \mathcal{B}_{\text{info}}(H_{1:t})$ (Jensen's inequality for the convex exponential); it is the form reported in the simulations of Sections 3 and 4.1. (b) Rearrange the first form of (a). (c) Apply (a) conditionally on t and average. The chain rule of mutual information [35, Sect. 2.5] gives the decomposition. For the inequality, (b) conditionally on t yields $I(T_t; H_{1:t} \mid t = \tau) \geq h(T_t \mid t = \tau) - \frac{1}{2} \ln(2\pi e\, \varepsilon_\tau^2)$ with ε_τ^2 the conditional MSE; averaging over τ and using Jensen's inequality for the concave logarithm [35, Sect. 2.6], $\mathbb{E}_\tau \ln \varepsilon_\tau^2 \leq \ln \mathbb{E}_\tau \varepsilon_\tau^2 = \ln \varepsilon^2$, gives the stated bound. □

Theorem 1 is the classical entropy-power bound on the error of an estimator [35, Sect. 8.6], used here to turn HI construction into an information budget; wherever the Bayesian Cramér–Rao bound applies, it is not weaker (Remark 3 in Appendix A).

Interpretation. Because $\mathcal{B}_{\text{info}} = e^{2h(T_t)-2I}/(2\pi e)$, an HI that retains I nats about the RUL cannot support an RMSE below e^{-I} times the bound for an HI that retains none: every 0.1 nat lowers the bound on the RMSE by about 10%. Part (b) turns the held-out MSE of any predictor into a number of nats, the *information lower bound*, which needs only the one-dimensional entropy $h(T_t)$, ranks HIs in the same order as the MSE and is negative, hence uninformative, when the predictor is inaccurate. Part (c) gives the relevant baseline. Since the age is always known, the reference for an HI is the RUL given the age, not the marginal RUL. A sensor-free predictor that uses only the age is a necessary baseline and a negative control, because it cannot attain a positive lower bound on the information beyond the age (Section 5.2). If the predictor uses the age, bound (b) already contains the age, and the difference between the bounds of an HI-and-age predictor and of an age-only predictor is a difference of two lower bounds that bounds nothing about the information the HI adds; only (c) does. The efficiency η_{info} could in principle be estimated before any predictor is trained, but mutual-information estimates are unreliable on small data sets [41, 42] (Appendix E).

3. A physics-constrained error budget

Assume that after inspection the latent degradation follows $dD_s = \mu\, ds + \sigma_B\, dW_s$, where W_s is a standard Wiener process, $\sigma_B > 0$ the diffusion coefficient and $\mu > 0$ a unit-specific drift (the random-effect formulation of [26, 27]) and with absorbing threshold D_{fail}. The prognostically relevant latent state is $\mathbf{z} = (D_t, \mu)$, where the inspection level D_t is *not* observed directly but only through $\mathbf{X}_{1:t}$. With $a = D_{\text{fail}} - D_t > 0$, the RUL is conditionally inverse-Gaussian [22, 24], $T_t \mid \mathbf{z} \sim \mathcal{IG}(m(\mathbf{z}),\, a^2/\sigma_B^2)$ with mean $m(\mathbf{z}) = a/\mu$ and variance $a\sigma_B^2/\mu^3$ [23], and T_t is independent of $\mathbf{X}_{1:t}$ (hence of $H_{1:t}$) given $\mathbf{z}$. Here $\mathcal{IG}(\text{mean}, \text{shape})$ denotes the inverse Gaussian distribution. Define the information efficiency about the mean RUL $m = m(\mathbf{z})$ as $\eta_m(H) := I(m; H_{1:t})/I(m; \mathbf{X}_{1:t}) \in [0, 1]$.

Theorem 2 (Physics-constrained bound)**.** *Assume $h(m \mid \mathbf{X}_{1:t})$ and $I(m; \mathbf{X}_{1:t})$ are finite. For any estimator $\hat{T}_t = g(H_{1:t})$ with finite second moment,*

$$\mathbb{E}[(T_t - \hat{T}_t)^2] \;\geq\; \underbrace{\mathbb{E}\left[\frac{a\,\sigma_B^2}{\mu^3}\right]}_{\mathcal{E}_{\text{aleatoric}}} + \underbrace{\mathbb{E}_H\left[\frac{e^{2h(m|H_{1:t}=\mathsf{h})}}{2\pi e}\right]}_{\mathcal{E}_{\text{epistemic}}}, \tag{6}$$

and the epistemic term obeys

$$\mathcal{E}_{\text{epistemic}} \;\geq\; \frac{1}{2\pi e} \exp\Big(2h(m \mid \mathbf{X}_{1:t}) + 2\big(1 - \eta_m(H)\big)\, I(m; \mathbf{X}_{1:t})\Big). \tag{7}$$

The aleatoric term does not depend on the HI.

Proof. Since $\mathbb{E}[T_t - m(\mathbf{z}) \mid \mathbf{z}, H_{1:t}] = 0$ and T_t is conditionally independent of $H_{1:t}$ given $\mathbf{z}$, the cross term vanishes and $\mathbb{E}[(T_t - \hat{T}_t)^2] = \mathbb{E}[\text{Var}(T_t \mid \mathbf{z})] + \mathbb{E}[(m(\mathbf{z}) - \hat{T}_t)^2]$, the usual split of the squared error into an irreducible and an estimation part [49, Sect. 1.5.5]. The first term is $\mathbb{E}[a\sigma_B^2/\mu^3]$. For the second, apply Theorem 1 conditionally on $H_{1:t} = \mathsf{h}$ to the target $m(\mathbf{z})$, which gives $\mathbb{E}[(m - \hat{T}_t)^2 \mid H = \mathsf{h}] \geq e^{2h(m|H=\mathsf{h})}/(2\pi e)$, and average over h. For the second inequality, the exponential is convex, so (Jensen [35, Sect. 2.6]) $\mathbb{E}_H[e^{2h(m|H=\mathsf{h})}] \geq e^{2h(m|H)}$ with $h(m \mid H) = \mathbb{E}_H h(m \mid H = \mathsf{h})$; and $m \to \mathbf{X}_{1:t} \to H_{1:t}$ is Markov, so $h(m \mid H) = h(m) - I(m; H) = h(m \mid \mathbf{X}) + I(m; \mathbf{X}) - I(m; H) = h(m \mid \mathbf{X}) + (1 - \eta_m) I(m; \mathbf{X})$. □

Table 1: Physics-constrained bound. $\mathcal{E}_{\text{ale}}$, $\mathcal{E}_{\text{epi}}$: aleatoric and epistemic terms (cycles^2); I in nats; errors in cycles.

ς	η_m	$I(m;H)$ [nats]	$\mathcal{E}_{\text{ale}}$	$\mathcal{E}_{\text{epi}}$ (exact)	$\mathcal{E}_{\text{epi}}$ (pointwise)	$\mathcal{E}_{\text{epi}}$ (Jensen)	$\sqrt{\text{bound}}$ [cycles]	Bayes RMSE [cycles]
0	1.00	1.40	63.9	86.6	75.7	34.3	11.81	12.26
2	0.96	1.35	64.0	91.2	80.1	37.9	12.00	12.46
4	0.91	1.28	63.4	99.0	86.6	44.1	12.25	12.74
8	0.80	1.13	63.8	121.5	106.4	59.7	13.05	13.61
16	0.63	0.88	62.9	174.7	150.9	97.3	14.62	15.42
32	0.38	0.53	63.8	318.7	265.0	198.6	18.13	19.56

Remark 1. *If the level D_t were known, a would be known and a change of variables would give $h(m \mid H, D_t) = h(\mu \mid H, D_t) + \mathbb{E}\ln(a/\mu^2)$. If the degradation followed the same constant-drift model from time 0 with $D_0 = 0$ and D_t were observed, D_t/t would be a sufficient statistic for μ and the resulting bound would not depend on the HI. The HI matters through the joint uncertainty about the level and the drift, which is why Theorem 2 is stated for the latent pair $\mathbf{z}$. The second inequality of the theorem (the Jensen form) is weaker than the first but depends on the HI only through η_m.*

The bound of Theorem 2 is conservative by an exact non-Gaussianity gap, the expected posterior variance of the mean RUL multiplied by $1 - e^{-2D}$, where D is the Kullback–Leibler (KL) divergence of the posterior from a Gaussian with the same mean and variance (Proposition 5 in Appendix A).

Numerical verification. The drift is $\mu \sim \mathcal{N}(1, 0.22^2)$, truncated to $\mu > 0.3$ and $a > 1$ (which keeps posterior sampling exact), with $\sigma_B = 0.85$, $D_{\text{fail}} = 100$ and $t = 50$. The raw sensor is $X_k = D_k + \xi_k$ with $\xi_k \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_\xi^2)$ and $\sigma_\xi = 1.5$. HIs with decreasing information are $H_k^\varsigma = X_k + \varsigma\zeta_k$ with independent standard normal ζ_k and $\varsigma \in \{0, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32\}$; each is a degraded version of X. The posterior of (D_t, μ) given H^ς is Gaussian (Kalman filter on (D, μ)), and $m = a/\mu$ is evaluated on 1500 posterior draws for each of 1500 test units; $h(m \mid H)$ and $h(m)$ are estimated with the Vasicek estimator [39]. The Bayes-optimal error is $\mathbb{E}[\text{Var}(T_t \mid \mathbf{z})] + \mathbb{E}[\text{Var}(m \mid H)]$, and the empirical error against simulated first-passage times is also reported. Errors are given as RMSE.

The aleatoric term is constant (≈ 63.8 cycles^2), whereas the epistemic term grows as η_m falls from 1 to 0.38 (Table 1). The pointwise bound stays below the Bayes-optimal error at every noise level (RMSE 11.8 against 12.3 cycles for $\varsigma = 0$, and 18.1 against 19.6 for $\varsigma = 32$). The exact epistemic variance exceeds the pointwise value because the posterior of m is not Gaussian; the mean KL divergence in Proposition 5 is about 0.07 nats at $\varsigma = 0$. The marginal density (B.1) of Appendix B, which marginalises the inverse-Gaussian distribution over the Gaussian drift, agrees with numerical integration of the mixture to within 0.31%. The entropy estimates carry Monte Carlo error that we did not quantify. For the aleatoric and the exact epistemic term at $\varsigma = 0$, three independent repetitions with 1500 test units gave 59.7 to 64.4 and 78.9 to 87.2 cycles^2, because the target a/μ has a heavy right tail, while the irreducible share stayed at 42 to 43%; gaps of a few per cent between the columns of Table 1 should therefore not be over-interpreted.

Engineering consequence. The aleatoric term is a floor that no HI can lower. In the example it is 64 cycles^2 against 87 cycles^2 of epistemic error for a lossless HI, so that about 42% of the squared error is irreducible; comparing the achieved error of a predictor

with this floor shows how much a better HI could still gain, and the epistemic term grows to 319 cycles^2 when the HI retains only 38% of the information in the sensors.

4. Four ways in which an HI loses information

An HI can lose information about the RUL in four ways that are common in practice: by template shrinkage that raises a geometric score (Section 4.1), by projection of the latent state on a static scalar (Section 4.2), by ignoring the operating regime (Section 4.3) and by integrating an estimated velocity without correction from the observations (Section 4.4). Each is stated as a result and checked on an exactly solvable model.

4.1. Template shrinkage: geometric criteria do not measure information

The geometric criteria of Coble and Hines [15] are computed from the shape of the HI. Monotonicity is $\mathrm{Mon}(H_{1:t}) = |\sum_{k=1}^{t-1} \mathrm{sgn}(H_{k+1} - H_k)|/(t-1)$, the balance of positive and negative increments. Prognosability is $\mathrm{Pro} = \exp(-\mathrm{std}(H_{\mathrm{end}})/\mathrm{mean}|H_{\mathrm{end}} - H_{\mathrm{start}}|)$, where the standard deviation and the mean are taken over units, H_{start} and H_{end} being the first and last values of each unit. In the benchmarks, Tre is the absolute correlation of the HI with time, as in [16] (and, under the name correlation, in [17]); it differs from the trendability of Coble and Hines, which measures the agreement of the functional form across units [15].

A strictly monotone bijection ϱ satisfies $I(T_t; \varrho(H_{1:t})) = I(T_t; H_{1:t})$, so information can be lost only through non-injective operations or noise. We therefore consider $\tilde{H}_{1:t} = \mathcal{S}(H_{1:t}, \xi)$, where ξ is independent of everything else. We call $\mathcal{S}$ a *template shrinkage* when it contracts the HI towards a template trajectory.

Theorem 3 (Template shrinkage)**.** *(a) For any such $\mathcal{S}$, $T_t \to H_{1:t} \to \tilde{H}_{1:t}$ is Markov, so $I(T_t; \tilde{H}_{1:t}) \le I(T_t; H_{1:t})$ and*

$$\mathcal{B}_{\mathrm{info}}(\tilde{H}_{1:t})/\mathcal{B}_{\mathrm{info}}(H_{1:t}) = \exp\big(2[I(T_t; H_{1:t}) - I(T_t; \tilde{H}_{1:t})]\big) \ge 1. \tag{8}$$

(b) Let the HI be the level D_k of a linear-Gaussian latent state, observed with Gaussian noise, $H_k = D_k + \xi_k^{(1)}$, and let the shrinkage with strength $\gamma \in [0, 1)$ and template (mean trajectory) $m_k = \mathbb{E}[D_k]$ be

$$\begin{gathered} \tilde{H}_k^{\gamma} = m_k + (1-\gamma)(H_k - m_k) + \xi_k^{(2)}, \\ \xi_k^{(2)} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_2^2) \text{ independent and identically distributed (i.i.d.)} \end{gathered} \tag{9}$$

For every linear functional ϑ of the latent state, for example the current velocity V_t, $\mathcal{I}_{\mathrm{tot}}^{\vartheta}(\gamma) := I(\vartheta; \tilde{H}_{1:t}^{\gamma})$ is non-increasing in γ and

$$\mathcal{I}_{\mathrm{tot}}^{\vartheta}(\gamma) \xrightarrow[\gamma \to 1]{} 0. \tag{10}$$

If the template has constant increment Δm, then, letting $\gamma \to 1$ and afterwards $t \to \infty$,

$$\mathrm{Mon}(\tilde{H}_{1:t}^{\gamma}) \to \mathrm{Mon}_{\infty} = 2\Phi_{\mathcal{N}}\big(\Delta m/(\sqrt{2}\,\sigma_2)\big) - 1, \tag{11}$$

where $\Phi_{\mathcal{N}}$ is the standard normal distribution function; the limit does not depend on the unit's own degradation.

Table 2: Template-shrinkage experiment (mean over three seeds; ±: standard deviation). Information about the velocity V_t in nats: $\mathcal{I}_{\text{state}} = I(V_t; \tilde{H}_t)$, $\mathcal{I}_{\text{kin}} = I(V_t; \Delta\tilde{H}_{2:t} \mid \tilde{H}_t)$, and $\eta_{\text{info}} = I(V_t; \tilde{H}_{1:t})/I(V_t; H_{1:t})$. $\sqrt{\mathcal{B}_{\text{info}}}$: pointwise form, errors in cycles.

γ	Mon	$\mathcal{I}_{\text{state}}$ [nats]	$\mathcal{I}_{\text{kin}}$ [nats]	η_{info}	$\sqrt{\mathcal{B}_{\text{info}}}$ [cycles]	Bayes RMSE [cycles]	Empirical RMSE [cycles]
0.000	0.496	0.789	0.092	1.00	6.67	8.04	15.0±9.8
0.500	0.766	0.779	0.092	0.99	6.81	8.91	14.9±9.4
0.900	0.975	0.567	0.188	0.85	7.38	9.27	15.3±9.2
0.970	0.981	0.159	0.396	0.63	9.01	10.99	17.1±9.2
0.990	0.981	0.022	0.200	0.25	12.87	15.20	21.2±8.9
0.995	0.982	0.006	0.070	0.09	14.88	17.83	23.2±8.9

Proof sketch. Part (a) follows from the data processing inequality. In (b) the shrunk HI is an invertible affine image of H observed through Gaussian noise whose variance grows without bound as $\gamma \to 1$, so the information vanishes, and the limit of Mon follows from the strong law of large numbers for the 1-dependent increments. The full proof is in Appendix A. □

Part (b) shows that the geometric score and the information content are decoupled. Once the shrinkage is strong, Mon saturates at a value set by the template and the noise, while the information available for RUL prediction keeps falling and the bound $\mathcal{B}_{\text{info}}$ keeps rising. The loss splits into a part about the current state and a part about the kinematics (Proposition 4 in Appendix A).

Numerical verification. The latent state is a local linear trend, $D_k = D_{k-1} + V_{k-1} + \sigma_B w_k$ and $V_k = V_{k-1} + \sigma_V \zeta_k$, with level D_k, velocity V_k, independent standard normal noises w_k, ζ_k and $V_0 \sim \mathcal{N}(\bar{v}, \sigma_{v0}^2)$. The raw HI is $H_k = D_k + \xi_k^{(1)}$ with measurement noise $\xi_k^{(1)} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_1^2)$, and the shrinkage is that of Theorem 3(b) with noise standard deviation σ_2. The parameters are $\bar{v} = 2$, $\sigma_{v0} = 0.25$, $\sigma_V = 0.03$, $\sigma_B = 0.5$, $\sigma_1 = 2$, $\sigma_2 = 0.6$, failure threshold $D_{\text{fail}} = 200$ and inspection at $t = 50$. The information about V_t is exact from the Kalman covariances [50, 51]. For the RUL, the Bayes-optimal estimator is the posterior mean from 300 exact posterior draws per unit, $h(T_t \mid \tilde{H})$ is estimated with the Vasicek estimator [39], and $\sqrt{\mathcal{B}_{\text{info}}}$ is the square root of the average of the pointwise entropy powers. Errors are reported as RMSE; each setting uses 400 test units and three seeds.

Monotonicity rises from 0.50 to 0.98 and saturates at the predicted value $\text{Mon}_\infty = 0.981$ for $\gamma \geq 0.97$ (Table 2, Figure 2), while from $\gamma = 0.9$ to 0.995 the efficiency falls from 0.85 to 0.09 and the Bayes-optimal RMSE nearly doubles (9.3 to 17.8 cycles). The bound stays below the Bayes-optimal error in every run. The state information falls monotonically, whereas the kinematic information first rises and then falls, so the increase of the bound at $\gamma = 0.9$ and 0.97 is driven by the loss of state information. The empirical RMSE varies strongly between seeds because of the heavy right tail of the RUL, and the posterior-based Bayes RMSE is the reliable summary.

Engineering consequence. Monotonicity, trendability and prognosability are not measures of information: an HI can be made to score higher by shrinking it toward a template while it loses information. They are not misleading by default: among candidate HIs derived from the sensors their ranking agreed with the information lower bound on turbofan

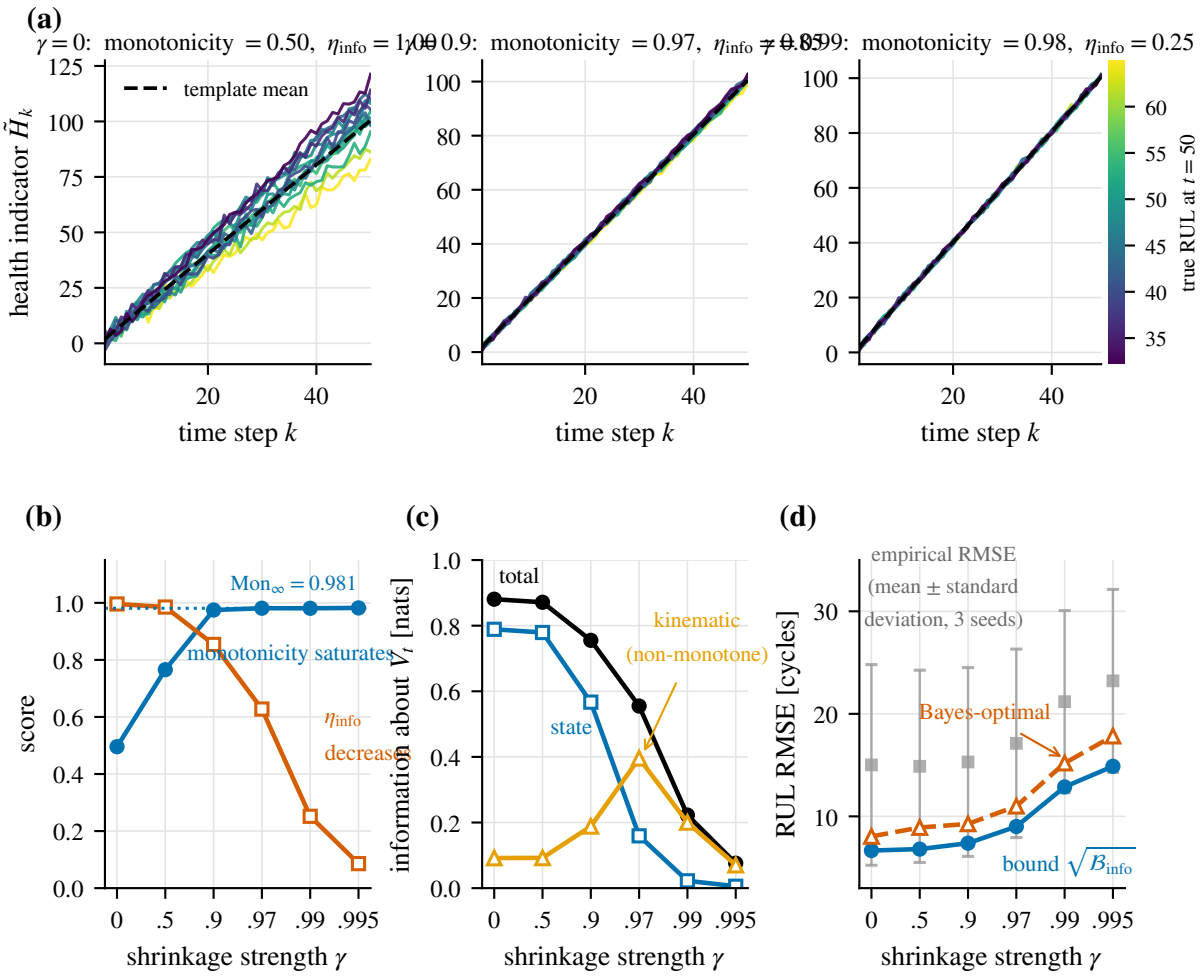


Figure 2: Template-shrinkage experiment. (a) HI paths of 14 units, coloured by the true RUL. (b) Monotonicity and efficiency. (c) Information about V_t. (d) Bound and RMSE (error bars: standard deviation over seeds). The values of γ are equally spaced.

engines but not reliably on lithium-ion cells (Section 5). Use them as screening scores and confirm the chosen HI by its information lower bound.

4.2. Projection: scalar indicators at the trajectory level

Theorem 2 concerns the information budget of an arbitrary HI. We now ask what a *scalar*, *static* HI loses when the degradation velocity varies in time. The loss has the same $\sin^2$ structure as the projection-misalignment loss at the snapshot level in [46], but it acts along the *temporal* direction (level versus velocity).

Setting. Let $\mathbf{z} = (D_t, V_t)^\top$ be the level and the velocity at inspection time t, with Gaussian prior $\mathcal{N}(\mathbf{z}_0, \boldsymbol{\Sigma})$, observed through $\mathbf{X}_{1:t}$ in a linear-Gaussian model (for example the local-linear-trend state space [51, 52] of Section 4.1 with Gaussian sensor noise). The posterior is $\mathcal{N}(\hat{\mathbf{z}}, \mathbf{P})$ where $\hat{\mathbf{z}} = \mathbb{E}[\mathbf{z} \mid \mathbf{X}_{1:t}]$ and $\mathbf{P}$ does not depend on the data (as for the covariance recursion of the Kalman filter [50, 51]); $\hat{\mathbf{z}} \sim \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{z}_0, \boldsymbol{\Lambda})$ with $\boldsymbol{\Lambda} = \boldsymbol{\Sigma} - \mathbf{P} \succ 0$ (law of total variance [49, Sect. 1.5.5]), and $\hat{\mathbf{z}}$ is a sufficient statistic of $\mathbf{X}_{1:t}$ for $\mathbf{z}$. The target is the frozen-velocity RUL $m(\mathbf{z}) = (D_{\mathrm{fail}} - D_t)/V_t$, which is nonlinear in $\mathbf{z}$. We linearise it at a *fixed*, non-random operating point $\bar{\mathbf{z}} = (\bar{D}, \bar{V})^\top$, for example the prior mean at the

inspection stage. Then

$$\mathbf{g} = \nabla m(\bar{\mathbf{z}}) = -\frac{1}{\bar{V}}\Big(1,\ \frac{\bar{a}}{\bar{V}}\Big)^{\top}, \qquad \bar{a} = D_{\text{fail}} - \bar{D}, \tag{12}$$

is a fixed vector, and $m_L(\mathbf{z}) = m(\bar{\mathbf{z}}) + \mathbf{g}^{\top}(\mathbf{z} - \bar{\mathbf{z}})$ is a fixed linear functional of $\mathbf{z}$. All statements of this section are exact for m_L; the error of replacing m by m_L is not covered by the theorems and is examined numerically below. A scalar *linear* HI built from the sufficient statistic, with fixed weights $\mathbf{u}$, is $h_{\mathbf{u}} = \mathbf{u}^{\top}\hat{\mathbf{z}}$. Define the signal-to-noise ratio $\rho = \mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{g}/\mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{P}\mathbf{g}$ and the $\mathbf{\Lambda}$-angle $\psi \in [0, \pi/2]$ between $\mathbf{g}$ and $\mathbf{u}$,

$$\cos\psi = \frac{|\mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{u}|}{\sqrt{(\mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{g})(\mathbf{u}^{\top}\mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{u})}}. \tag{13}$$

Theorem 4 (Angular loss relation)**.** *In the setting above, for every fixed* $\mathbf{u} \neq 0$*:*
(a) $\mathrm{Var}(m_L \mid h_{\mathbf{u}}) = \mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{P}\mathbf{g} + (\mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{g})\sin^2\psi$*.*
(b) For the linearised target, with $\mathcal{B}_{\text{info}}$*,* $\mathcal{B}_{\min}$ *and* η_m *defined as in Theorem 1 and Section 3 with* m_L *in place of* T_t *and* m*, and with* $I(m_L; \mathbf{X}_{1:t}) = \frac{1}{2}\ln(1+\rho)$*,*

$$\frac{\mathcal{B}_{\text{info}}(h_{\mathbf{u}})}{\mathcal{B}_{\min}} = 1 + \rho\sin^2\psi, \qquad \eta_m(h_{\mathbf{u}}) = 1 - \frac{\ln(1+\rho\sin^2\psi)}{\ln(1+\rho)}. \tag{14}$$

(c) $\eta_m(h_{\mathbf{u}}) = 1$ *if and only if* $\mathbf{u} \parallel \mathbf{g}$*; the HI* $h_{\mathbf{g}} = \mathbf{g}^{\top}\hat{\mathbf{z}}$ *is information-lossless for* m_L *and is, by Lemma 1 (Appendix A), the best scalar linear HI of* $\mathbf{X}_{1:t}$*.*

Proof. (a) Because $\mathbf{z} = \hat{\mathbf{z}} + \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}$ with $\boldsymbol{\varepsilon} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \mathbf{P})$ independent of $\hat{\mathbf{z}}$, we have $\mathrm{Cov}(\mathbf{z}, \hat{\mathbf{z}}) = \mathbf{\Lambda}$ and $\mathrm{Var}(\mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{z}) = \mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{\Sigma}\mathbf{g} = \mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{g} + \mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{P}\mathbf{g}$. The pair $(\mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{z}, h_{\mathbf{u}})$ is jointly Gaussian with $\mathrm{Cov} = \mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{u}$ and $\mathrm{Var}(h_{\mathbf{u}}) = \mathbf{u}^{\top}\mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{u}$, so the Gaussian conditioning formula [49, Sect. 2.3] gives $\mathrm{Var}(m_L \mid h_{\mathbf{u}}) = \mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{g} + \mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{P}\mathbf{g} - (\mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{u})^2/(\mathbf{u}^{\top}\mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{u}) = \mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{P}\mathbf{g} + \mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{g}\,(1 - \cos^2\psi)$.
(b) In the linearised model the conditional distribution of m_L is Gaussian, so the entropy power equals the variance. Taking the ratio of (a) to the case $h = \hat{\mathbf{z}}$, for which $\mathrm{Var}(m_L \mid \hat{\mathbf{z}}) = \mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{P}\mathbf{g}$, gives the first formula. Moreover, by the formula for the mutual information of jointly Gaussian variables [35, Chap. 8], $I(m_L; \mathbf{X}) = \frac{1}{2}\ln(\mathrm{Var}(m_L)/\mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{P}\mathbf{g}) = \frac{1}{2}\ln(1+\rho)$ and $I(m_L; h_{\mathbf{u}}) = \frac{1}{2}\ln\big((1+\rho)/(1+\rho\sin^2\psi)\big)$; their ratio is η_m.
(c) $\sin^2\psi = 0$ iff $\mathbf{\Lambda}^{1/2}\mathbf{g} \parallel \mathbf{\Lambda}^{1/2}\mathbf{u}$ iff $\mathbf{u} \parallel \mathbf{g}$ since $\mathbf{\Lambda} \succ 0$. For $\mathbf{u} = \mathbf{g}$ the loss vanishes, and Lemma 1 shows that no scalar linear functional of $\mathbf{X}$ can do better. □

Remark 2 (Scope of the angular relation)**.** *The theorem concerns scalar* linear *HIs with fixed weights and the linearised target. If the operating point is replaced by the posterior mean* $\hat{\mathbf{z}}$ *of each unit, the gradient becomes a function of the data, and the theorem then describes the loss conditionally on freezing the gradient, that is, a local analysis around the unit's own estimate. An HI with unit-specific weights is a nonlinear scalar function of* $\hat{\mathbf{z}}$ *and is not covered by the optimality statements, which also do not exclude nonlinear scalar HIs with fixed structure.*

Corollary 1 (No static scalar linear HI is optimal over the whole life)**.** *(a) In the coordinates* (D_t, V_t) *the optimal direction is* $\mathbf{g}_t \propto (1, \bar{\tau}_t)^{\top}$*, with* $\bar{\tau}_t = \bar{a}_t/\bar{V}_t$ *the frozen-velocity RUL (in steps) at the operating point of stage* t*. The optimal scalar linear HI therefore weights the velocity estimate* $\bar{\tau}_t$ *times more than the level estimate; the weight moves from the velocity (early life,* $\bar{\tau}_t$ *large) to the level (end of life,* $\bar{\tau}_t \to 0$*), and the Euclidean angle*

Table 3: Factor by which the bound increases at $t = 50$, mean over 500 units: prediction at the fixed operating point, prediction at the unit's own estimate, and Monte Carlo for the exact target. ψ: angle to the unit-specific gradient.

HI	mean ψ [deg]	fixed point	unit gradient	Monte Carlo
level only $\mathbf{u} = (1, 0)$	6.0	1.179	1.177	1.181
velocity only $\mathbf{u} = (0, 1)$	5.8	1.164	1.194	1.197
stage-fixed gradient (prior mean)	0.7	1.000	1.004	1.003
unit-specific gradient	0.0	1.004	1.000	0.999

between the optimal directions at RULs τ_1, τ_2 is $|\arctan\tau_1 - \arctan\tau_2|$.
(b) Let $\mathbf{g}_1, \mathbf{g}_2$ be the gradients at the operating points of two inspection stages with information matrices $\mathbf{\Lambda}_1, \mathbf{\Lambda}_2$ and ratios $\rho_1, \rho_2 > 0$. If $\mathbf{g}_1 \not\parallel \mathbf{g}_2$, then for every fixed $\mathbf{u}$ the bound is increased at one of the two stages, $\max_j \rho_j \sin^2\psi_j(\mathbf{u}) \geq \delta > 0$; if $\mathbf{\Lambda}_1 = \mathbf{\Lambda}_2$, then $\delta \geq \min_j \rho_j \sin^2(\psi_{12}/2)$ with ψ_{12} the $\mathbf{\Lambda}$-angle between $\mathbf{g}_1$ and $\mathbf{g}_2$. A stage-wise HI that uses the weights $\mathbf{g}_j$ at stage j does not increase the bound, relative to the linearised target, at any stage.

Proof sketch. Part (a) is the gradient formula above, and (b) follows from Theorem 4(c), which makes the increase of the bound at stage j vanish only for $\mathbf{u} \parallel \mathbf{g}_j$, and from the triangle inequality for the $\mathbf{\Lambda}$-angle between lines. The full proof is in Appendix A. □

Corollary 1(a) explains why an indicator built from a level-like feature, for example the first principal component of cumulative-damage features, loses information early in life, and why a velocity-like feature loses it late in life. It is the temporal counterpart of the snapshot-level rotation of the signal direction. It also motivates the predictor of Appendix B.3, which uses both the smoothed HI level and its windowed slope: this pair estimates the two-dimensional sufficient statistic $\hat{\mathbf{z}}$.

Numerical verification. The model is the local linear trend of Section 4.1 with the raw sensor and $D_{\text{fail}} = 200$. The posterior of $\mathbf{z} = (D_t, V_t)$ is Gaussian, and $\mathbf{\Lambda}$ is strongly anisotropic (eigenvalues 0.004 and 204). For each of 500 units, the exact entropy power of the *nonlinear* target $m = (D_{\text{fail}} - D_t)/V_t$ given $h_{\mathbf{u}}$ is estimated from the exact conditional Gaussian of $\mathbf{z}$ (2000 draws, Vasicek estimator) and compared with $1 + \rho\sin^2\psi$ computed in two ways: at a fixed operating point, the prior mean of the stage, as in Theorem 4; and at the unit's own posterior mean, a local analysis in the sense of Remark 2. As a consistency check, in the constant-drift model of Section 3 $\mathbf{\Lambda}$ is effectively of rank one and the predicted factor is 1.000 for every $\mathbf{u}$ (Monte Carlo: 1.000 to 1.003), as the remark after Theorem 2 implies.

At $t = 50$ both predictions agree with the Monte Carlo value within about 3% for all HIs (Table 3). The values at the other inspection times illustrate Corollary 1. The static HI aligned at $t^* = 50$ is lossless at $t = 25$ and 50 but raises the bound by about 40% at $t = 75$ (Monte Carlo 1.39), the level-only HI by about 37% and the velocity-only HI by a factor of about 5. The prediction at the fixed prior-mean operating point agrees with Monte Carlo at $t = 25$ and 50 but underestimates the late-life increase of the bound for the static and the velocity-only HI (1.12 and 3.5 at $t = 75$), because the gradient of the nonlinear target at the prior mean differs from that at the units' own estimates; the prediction with the unit's own gradient (1.40 and 5.1) agrees within 3%. The linear theory is therefore an accurate local approximation but not an exact statement for the nonlinear target.

Engineering consequence. A static scalar HI is adequate only when the stage-optimal directions are close. Otherwise pass the level and the velocity of the HI to the predictor, as the windowed slope does in our predictor, or let the weights follow the stage of life.

4.3. Regime-blind estimation

When the sensors are recorded under several operating regimes, the sensor responds to the degradation with a regime-dependent offset and gain, whereas the degradation process itself is the same. The following statement quantifies what a regime-blind estimator loses.

Proposition 1 (Error floor of a regime-blind estimator)**.** *Let a latent level D with mean $\bar{d}$ and variance v be observed through a sensor as $x = c_r D + o_r + \varepsilon$, where the regime r takes R values with probabilities p_r independently of D and of the noise ε (variance σ^2); c_r and o_r are the gain and offset of regime r (all $c_r \neq 0$). Put $\bar{c} = \mathbb{E}c_r$ and $V_x := \mathrm{Var}(x) = \mathbb{E}[c_r^2]\mathbb{E}[D^2] - (\bar{c}\bar{d})^2 + \mathrm{Var}(o_r) + 2\bar{d}\,\mathrm{Cov}(c_r, o_r) + \sigma^2$. The best regime-blind linear estimator of D from x has mean squared error*

$$\mathrm{MSE}_{\mathrm{blind}} = v - \frac{\bar{c}^2 v^2}{V_x}, \qquad \textit{and} \qquad \mathrm{MSE}_{\mathrm{blind}} \xrightarrow[\sigma\to 0]{} \frac{v\,[\mathrm{Var}(c_r)\,v + \mathrm{Var}(\bar{d}c_r + o_r)]}{\bar{c}^2 v + \mathrm{Var}(c_r)\,v + \mathrm{Var}(\bar{d}c_r + o_r)} > 0 \tag{15}$$

unless the regimes agree in c_r and in $\bar{d}c_r + o_r$, whereas the estimator $(x - o_r)/c_r$ that knows the regime attains $\mathrm{MSE}_{\mathrm{aware}} = \sigma^2 \sum_r p_r / c_r^2 \to 0$.

Proof. Because D and r are independent, $\mathrm{Cov}(D, x) = \bar{c}\,v$, and $\mathrm{Var}(x) = \mathrm{Var}(c_r D) + \mathrm{Var}(o_r) + 2\bar{d}\,\mathrm{Cov}(c_r, o_r) + \sigma^2 = V_x$, since $\mathrm{Cov}(c_r D, o_r) = \bar{d}\,\mathrm{Cov}(c_r, o_r)$ and $\mathrm{Var}(c_r D) = \mathbb{E}[c_r^2]\mathbb{E}[D^2] - (\bar{c}\bar{d})^2$; the best linear predictor of D from x has error $v - \mathrm{Cov}(D, x)^2 / \mathrm{Var}(x)$ (the conditional variance of a Gaussian pair with the same second moments [49, Sect. 2.3]). For the limit use $\mathbb{E}[c_r^2]\mathbb{E}[D^2] - (\bar{c}\bar{d})^2 = \bar{c}^2 v + \mathrm{Var}(c_r)(v + \bar{d}^2)$ and $\mathrm{Var}(c_r)\bar{d}^2 + \mathrm{Var}(o_r) + 2\bar{d}\mathrm{Cov}(c_r, o_r) = \mathrm{Var}(\bar{d}c_r + o_r)$, so that at $\sigma = 0$, $V_x = \bar{c}^2 v + \mathrm{Var}(c_r)v + \mathrm{Var}(\bar{d}c_r + o_r)$. Given the regime, the estimator $(x - o_r)/c_r$ is unbiased with variance σ^2/c_r^2. □

Normalising the sensors within each regime removes the regime offsets but not the regime-dependent gains, so the floor remains. In a numerical example with six regimes ($c_r \in [0.6, 1.6]$, $o_r \in [-0.5, 0.6]$, $v = 0.08$), the formula and a simulation agree on $\mathrm{MSE}_{\mathrm{blind}} = 0.060$ at $\sigma = 0$, so that only 25% of $\mathrm{Var}(D)$ is explained, whereas the regime-aware estimator has an error that tends to zero.

Engineering consequence. Normalise the sensors by operating regime and, when protocols differ between units, by each unit's own early cycles. Per-regime normalisation removes offsets but not gains, so the regime should also be given to the observation model when gains differ.

4.4. Integration without observation correction

An HI that integrates an estimated velocity u_k, $H_k = H_{k-1} + u_k$, has nothing that anchors its level to the observations. Section 4.2 treats the level and the velocity as latent quantities, and the level must be re-estimated from the sensors at every step; this is the measurement update of a Kalman filter [50]. An observation-corrected HI adds a direct level estimate l_k and a gain $\omega_k \in (0, 1)$, $H_k = (1 - \omega_k)(H_{k-1} + u_k) + \omega_k\, l_k$, and $\omega = 0$ is the pure integrator. The next proposition quantifies what the integrator accumulates.

Proposition 2 (Error accumulation without observation correction)**.** *Let the velocity estimate carry the error $e_k = b + w_k$ with a unit-specific persistent bias b and white noise w_k of variance σ_w^2, and let the direct level estimate l_k carry independent zero-mean noise n_k of variance σ_n^2. Let ε_k be the error of the HI level. Conditionally on b, the pure integrator ($\omega = 0$) has at step t an error with mean tb and variance $t\sigma_w^2$, both unbounded in t. For a constant gain $\omega \in (0, 1]$ the error converges to a stationary distribution ε_∞ with*

$$\mathbb{E}\,\varepsilon_\infty = \frac{(1-\omega)\,b}{\omega}, \qquad \operatorname{Var}\,\varepsilon_\infty = \frac{(1-\omega)^2\sigma_w^2 + \omega^2\sigma_n^2}{\omega(2-\omega)}. \tag{16}$$

Proof. The level error obeys $\varepsilon_k = (1-\omega)(\varepsilon_{k-1} + e_k) + \omega n_k$ with $\varepsilon_0 = 0$ (substitute $H_k = D_k + \varepsilon_k$, $u_k = v_k + e_k$ and $l_k = D_k + n_k$ into the update, with $D_k = D_{k-1} + v_k$ the true level and v_k its true increment); write $\alpha = 1 - \omega$. For $\omega = 0$, $\varepsilon_t = \sum_{k \le t} e_k$ has mean tb and variance $t\sigma_w^2$. For $\omega > 0$ the mean $\bar{\varepsilon}_k$ satisfies $\bar{\varepsilon}_k = \alpha(\bar{\varepsilon}_{k-1} + b)$, with fixed point $\alpha b/(1-\alpha) = (1-\omega)b/\omega$ approached geometrically, and the variance $s_k^2 = \alpha^2 s_{k-1}^2 + \alpha^2\sigma_w^2 + \omega^2\sigma_n^2$ (independent noise terms) has fixed point $(\alpha^2\sigma_w^2 + \omega^2\sigma_n^2)/(1-\alpha^2)$ with $1 - \alpha^2 = \omega(2-\omega)$. □

A simulation ($b = 0.01$, $\sigma_w = 0.02$, $\sigma_n = 0.15$, 400 steps, 2×10^5 paths) agrees with both expressions (for $\omega = 0$ the bias is $4.00 = tb$; for $\omega = 0.2$ the bias and variance are 0.0399 and 0.00321 against 0.04 and 0.00321). A constant gain amounts to exponential smoothing, the steady state of the local-level filter [51, 52]. A persistent velocity bias is the generic situation when units differ in initial offset or wear, and it is consistent with the behaviour of the integrating encoder on the turbofan data, whose error falls once the correction is added (Section 6). Two learned encoders implement this correction with a learned gain: PGIB-KF, an observation-corrected (Kalman-filter-based) variant of the physics-guided information bottleneck (PGIB), and its regime-aware variant PGIB-KFR. They are described in Appendix B and compared with simple HIs in Section 6.

Engineering consequence. An encoder that integrates a velocity needs an observation correction: a gain on a direct level estimate turns an unbounded error into a bounded one.

5. Tests on real data

This section tests the predictions of Sections 2 to 4 directly, on two domains with many units: turbofan engines (the four subsets FD001 to FD004 of the Commercial Modular Aero-Propulsion System Simulation (C-MAPSS) data, 100 to 260 training engines) and lithium-ion cells (the HUST, MATR and Tongji collections, with 77, 169 and 88 cells). Estimators are compared in Section 6.

5.1. Data and design

All analyses use unit-grouped five-fold cross-validation: preprocessing, HIs and predictors are fitted on the training units of a fold and evaluated on its held-out units. The population consists of pairs of a unit and an age t between a minimum age (30 cycles for engines, 100, 50 and 30 cycles for the HUST, MATR and Tongji cells) and the age at which 10% of the training units are still alive. Pooling all ages of all units gives $T_t \mid t$ the distribution of $L - t$ given $L > t$, where L is the lifetime of a unit, so that $h(T_t \mid t)$ is estimated from the lifetime distribution of the training units (Gaussian kernel density of

$\ln L$) without further assumption; $\bar{h}(T_t \mid t)$ denotes its average over the pairs, the quantity $\mathbb{E}_t\, h(T_t \mid t)$ of Theorem 1(c). Predictors are gradient-boosted trees on summaries of the HI trajectory and the age, and confidence intervals are bootstrap intervals over units (Appendix F).

Turbofan engines. The training sets of the four C-MAPSS subsets are used (FD001 and FD003: one operating regime; FD002 and FD004: six regimes), with 14 informative sensors standardised within regime where there are several. The HIs are a ridge regression of the life fraction (age divided by lifetime) on the standardised sensors (ridge HI) and the first principal component of the sensors (PCA-HI); a predictor on the raw sensors is the reference.

Lithium-ion cells. The HUST collection (Huazhong University of Science and Technology) [53] contains 77 lithium iron phosphate/graphite cells, each cycled under its own multi-stage charge and discharge protocol, with end of life at 80% of the initial capacity (977 to 2334 cycles; coefficient of variation of the lifetime 0.19). The MATR collection [20, 54] contains 169 cells of the same chemistry cycled under fast-charging protocols, with end of life at 80% of the nominal capacity (147 to 2235 cycles; coefficient of variation 0.42). The Tongji collection [55] contains 88 cells (of 130 recorded) of three nickel-based chemistries (lithium nickel cobalt aluminium oxide, lithium nickel manganese cobalt oxide and a blend, with graphite or graphite/silicon anodes), cycled at 25, 35 and 45 °C under several protocols, with end of life at 80% of the nominal capacity (121 to 570 cycles; coefficient of variation 0.37); the other cells did not reach this threshold within the recordings or had lifetimes shorter than 100 cycles. The three collections were taken from the processed BatteryLife repository [56]. The HIs use only features of the charging phase (charge duration and charge voltage at 27% and 73% of the nominal capacity, that is 0.3 and 0.8 Ah for the 1.1 Ah cells), each expressed relative to cycles 2 to 11 of the same cell. The discharge capacity, which defines the end of life, enters only a reference predictor. Time scales are matched to the lifetimes (Appendix F).

5.2. Age-conditional information lower bound

Turbofan engines (Theorem 1(c)). The information lower bound is $\bar{h}(T_t \mid t) - \frac{1}{2}\ln(2\pi e\,\mathrm{MSE}) \le I(T_t; H_{1:t} \mid t)$. A predictor that uses only the age is a negative control, since its lower bound cannot exceed zero when the lifetime distribution is correct; it is -0.22 to -0.11 nats on FD001 to FD004 (Table 5). The HI trajectory carries information beyond the age (Figure 3(a)): the lower bound for the ridge HI is 0.10 to 0.31 nats, with 95% intervals excluding zero except on FD003. Level-only and slope-only summaries of the same HI give lower bounds below that of the full trajectory on FD001, FD002 and FD004. A predictor on the raw sensors gives 0.16 to 0.25 nats, similar to the supervised HI and higher on FD003 and FD004, so the HI is a compression of the sensors that retains at best the information they contain, not an addition to it. With 100 or more engines the lower bound is positive and passes its control.

Lithium-ion cells. The age-only control is at or below zero on HUST and MATR and 0.05 nats on Tongji, whose interval includes zero, and the lower bound for the ridge HI is 0.30 to 0.60 nats with intervals above zero (Figure 3(a), Table 5). The three charging features used directly give higher lower bounds (0.61 to 0.91 nats) than the scalar HI constructed from them, as the data processing inequality requires, and the capacity reference does not exceed them.

Table 4: Geometric score versus information lower bound over 42 candidate HIs per data set. ρ_S: Spearman correlation with the information lower bound (95% bootstrap interval over HIs).

Data set	HIs	ρ_S (score)	ρ_S (Mon)	rank of the highest-score HI	lower bound: highest-score HI / best HI
FD001	42	0.97 [0.93, 0.98]	0.85 [0.67, 0.95]	2	0.23 / 0.30
FD002	42	0.89 [0.77, 0.97]	0.59 [0.30, 0.80]	1	0.21 / 0.21
FD003	42	0.82 [0.66, 0.91]	0.58 [0.30, 0.79]	1	0.15 / 0.15
FD004	42	0.64 [0.40, 0.79]	0.59 [0.33, 0.77]	1	0.20 / 0.20
HUST	42	0.08 [-0.22, 0.38]	0.52 [0.31, 0.68]	18	0.28 / 0.57
MATR	42	0.74 [0.57, 0.85]	0.75 [0.61, 0.84]	8	0.25 / 0.43
Tongji	42	0.16 [-0.18, 0.46]	0.18 [-0.15, 0.48]	16	0.56 / 0.84

Small data sets. On the seven small battery and bearing sets of Section 6 the model-based age-conditional lower bound fails the negative control on four of them, because a log-normal lifetime distribution fitted to three to seven lifetimes overestimates $h(T_t \mid t)$ (Table D.11). Among the data sets tested, the bound was positive and passed its control only with 77 or more units; subsets of the larger sets put the threshold near 40 (Section 5.8).

5.3. Template shrinkage

Turbofan engines (Theorem 3). Shrinkage toward the mean HI trajectory of the training engines, with noise chosen as in Section 4.1, raises the monotonicity of the ridge HI from 0.13–0.24 to 0.41–0.58, where it saturates for $\gamma \geq 0.97$ at the value predicted from the template (0.41–0.58 observed against 0.41–0.61 predicted; Figure 3(b)). Over the same range the information lower bound falls from 0.10–0.31 nats to about zero or below (Figure 3(c)).

Lithium-ion cells. Template shrinkage raises the monotonicity of the ridge HI from 0.32 to 0.81 on HUST, from 0.39 to 0.48 on MATR and from 0.65 to 0.73 on Tongji, close to the predicted limits (0.82, 0.49 and 0.70), while the lower bound falls to about zero or below on all three (Figure 3(b,c)). In both domains, monotonicity and the information lower bound are decoupled.

5.4. Geometric scores and information lower bound

The template shrinkage above is a constructed example. To see whether geometric scores agree with the information bound among realistic HIs, each data set was given 42 candidate HIs (40 random linear combinations of the normalised sensors or charging features, the PCA-HI and the ridge HI), and the score Mon +Tre + Pro was compared with the age-conditional information lower bound (Appendix F). On the four turbofan subsets the two agree: the Spearman correlation is 0.64 to 0.97, with bootstrap intervals above 0.4, and the HI with the highest score ranks first or second of 42 by its information lower bound (Table 4). On the cells the results are inconsistent. On HUST and Tongji the correlation is indistinguishable from zero (0.08 and 0.16), and on MATR it is 0.74. On all three, however, the highest-score HI ranks only 18th, 8th and 16th, with lower bounds of 0.28, 0.25 and 0.56 nats against 0.57, 0.43 and 0.84 for the best HI, that is, about half to two thirds. Geometric scores are therefore a reasonable screen on the engines and not reliable on the cells; we did not investigate the cause.

5.5. Direction of a scalar linear HI

Turbofan engines (Theorem 4, Corollary 1). For the level and the velocity of the ridge HI, the direction of the best linear scalar combination for the RUL, measured as the angle

from the level axis, moves across stages (for example between 21° and 56° across age stages on FD002). Level-only and velocity-only HIs lose up to 20% and 38% of RMSE relative to the best direction chosen separately at each stage (Figure 4(b,c)). However, the best *static* direction, combined with a stage-specific affine map, loses at most 4% in every stage and subset. The relation of Section 4.2 is therefore consistent with the observed rotation, but its consequence is small on these data; the factor $1 + \rho \sin^2 \psi$ depends on the signal-to-noise ratio ρ as well as on the angle, and ρ was not estimated here.

Lithium-ion cells. On HUST the optimal direction moves from 71°–80° in the first three life stages to 3°–16° in the last two, and the best static direction loses up to 9% of RMSE in a stage (18% in the last age stage), against up to 54% for velocity alone (Figure 4(b,c)). On MATR the optimal direction also rotates across the life fraction (88° to 42°), but a static direction loses at most 1.2%; on Tongji it loses at most 3% across life stages and 7% across age stages, against up to 35% for the level alone. The loss predicted by the angular relation is thus material for HUST, modest for Tongji and negligible for MATR and for engines.

5.6. Operating regime and test protocol

Turbofan engines (Proposition 1). For a linear estimator of the life fraction, regime blindness increases the RMSE from 0.137 to 0.148 on FD002 and from 0.165 to 0.199 on FD004 (8% and 21%); with one regime the three estimators coincide. Per-regime normalisation removes most of the loss, and regime-specific weights add only 1%, so the residual effect of heterogeneous gains is small in these data.

Lithium-ion cells. A linear estimator of the life fraction from the raw charging features, standardised over the population, has an RMSE of 0.136 on HUST and 0.179 on MATR; expressing each feature relative to the own early cycles of the cell, which removes the protocol- and cell-specific level, lowers it to 0.115 and 0.142 (18% and 26%), and from 0.190 to 0.167 (14%) on Tongji. This is the analogue of regime normalisation of Proposition 1, with the cell corresponding to the regime.

5.7. What the information lower bound adds to the RMSE

The RMSE in cycles cannot be compared across data sets: the age-only predictor has an RMSE between 45 and 328 cycles, which reflects the lifetime scale (Table 5). The ratio to the age-only RMSE is scale-free, and the gain in the information lower bound over the age-only predictor is exactly its logarithm, $\ln(\mathrm{RMSE}_{\mathrm{age}}/\mathrm{RMSE}_{\mathrm{HI}})$, so that a gain of 0.3 nats is an RMSE lower by about 26% on every data set. Within one data set the information lower bound ranks predictors exactly as the RMSE does and adds no new ranking. It adds two things that the RMSE does not give. First, an absolute check: the age-only predictor cannot exceed zero if the lifetime distribution is correct. Its value shows how conservative the bound is (-0.27 nats on MATR, -0.02 on HUST), and it indicated the mismatch between the training distribution and the FD003 test engines ($+0.33$ nats), which no comparison of RMSE values would have revealed. Second, an information reading that applies to any predictor, including an end-to-end one (Section 6).

5.8. Number of units needed

Estimating the information lower bound requires run-to-failure units, so an engineer must know how many. Random subsets of k units were drawn from each data set (10

Table 5: RMSE and information lower bound of the age-only predictor and of the ridge HI (cross-validation). Gain: difference of the information lower bounds, equal to ln of the RMSE ratio.

Data set	Median life	RMSE [cycles]			Lower bound [nats]		
	[cycles]	age only	ridge HI	ratio	age only	ridge HI	gain
FD001	199	45	29	0.66	-0.11	0.31	0.42
FD002	199	45	33	0.73	-0.11	0.21	0.32
FD003	220	85	62	0.73	-0.22	0.10	0.32
FD004	234	68	51	0.74	-0.12	0.18	0.30
HUST	1708	301	218	0.72	-0.02	0.30	0.32
MATR	760	328	181	0.55	-0.27	0.32	0.60
Tongji	363	92	53	0.58	0.05	0.60	0.55

Table 6: Share of valid random subsets of k units (mean gain in the information lower bound over the age-only control, in nats, in brackets); 10 subsets per size, '–' if k exceeds 80% of the units.

Data set	$k = 5$	$k = 10$	$k = 20$	$k = 40$	$k = 80$	$k = 120$
FD001	0.5 (0.10)	0.6 (0.17)	0.7 (0.16)	1.0 (0.26)	1.0 (0.33)	–
FD002	0.4 (0.08)	0.5 (0.08)	0.7 (0.14)	1.0 (0.21)	1.0 (0.22)	–
FD003	0.4 (-0.05)	0.4 (0.11)	0.6 (0.19)	1.0 (0.25)	1.0 (0.34)	–
FD004	0.3 (-0.06)	0.4 (0.06)	0.3 (0.08)	0.7 (0.14)	1.0 (0.24)	–
HUST	0.2 (-0.09)	0.3 (0.12)	0.6 (0.13)	0.9 (0.26)	–	–
MATR	0.3 (0.06)	0.7 (0.32)	1.0 (0.30)	0.9 (0.42)	1.0 (0.44)	1.0 (0.57)
Tongji	0.2 (0.30)	0.0 (0.20)	0.0 (0.19)	0.1 (0.41)	–	–

subsets per size), the unit-grouped cross-validation was repeated on each, and a subset was called *valid* when the ridge HI exceeded the age-only predictor by more than 0.1 nat while the control stayed at or below 0.05 nat (Table 6). With 5 units the share of valid subsets was 0.2 to 0.5; with 40 units it was 0.9 to 1.0, except 0.7 on FD004 and 0.1 on Tongji. Tongji did not reach a valid share in subsets of up to 40 cells because its age-only control stayed at 0.11 to 0.22 nats and fell to 0.05 only with all 88 cells (Section 5.2); its three chemistries and temperatures make the lifetime distribution harder to estimate. The number of units needed therefore depends on the heterogeneity of the fleet, and the control must be checked in every case. Subsets of a size close to the data set overlap, and the thresholds are conventions, so the result is an order of magnitude: about 40 units for a decision, and fewer than 10 units are unreliable.

5.9. Sensitivity to the inclusion rule on Tongji

Excluding the 33 of the 130 recorded Tongji cells that never reached the end-of-life threshold removes long-lived cells (right censoring). Counting the 31 of them with at least 100 recorded cycles as failed at their last recorded cycle biases the lifetimes downward in the other direction, so the two rules bound the effect (Table F.12, Appendix F). The age-only control still passes (-0.04 nats) and the ridge HI still carries information beyond the age (lower bound 0.31 nats, interval 0.23 to 0.43), but the information lower bound halves from 0.60, the loss of a static direction rises from 7% to 9%, and the protocol effect falls from 14% to 5%. The qualitative conclusions hold; the size of the effects on Tongji depends on how censored cells are treated.

6. Benchmark of estimators

Section 5 tests the theory with generic HIs. This section asks what the theory implies for estimators, and makes three predictions that run-to-failure data can test. (i) A sensor-free predictor that uses only the age should be competitive when the sensors are

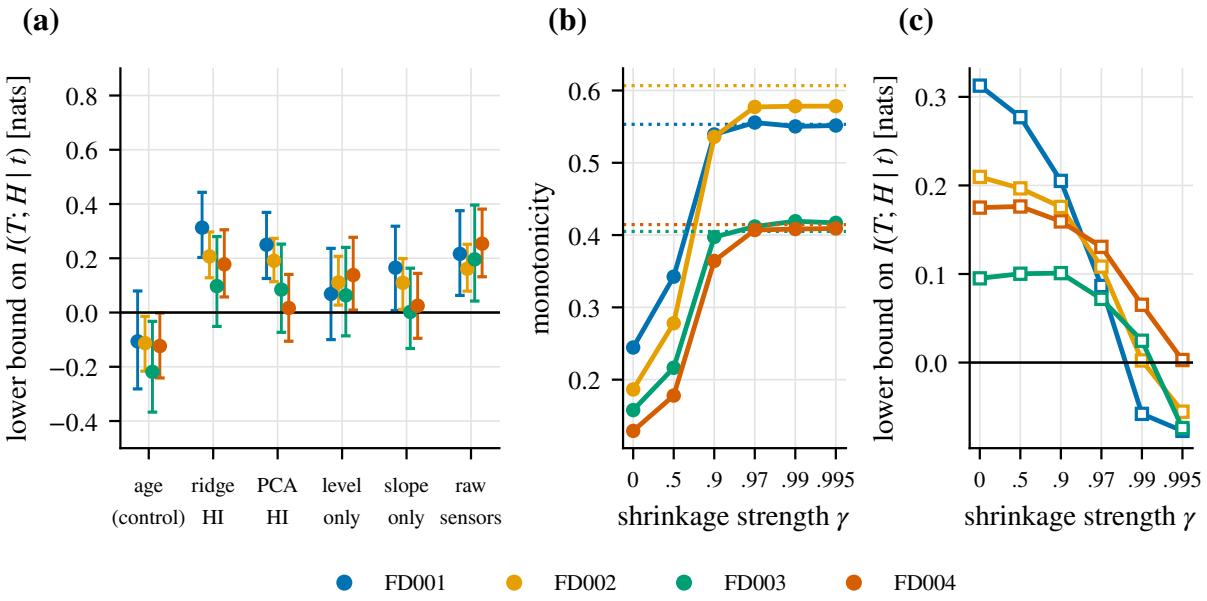


Figure 3: Cross-validated tests on turbofan engines (FD001–FD004) and lithium-ion cells (HUST, MATR, Tongji). (a) Lower bound on $I(T_t; H_{1:t} \mid t)$ for HI summaries, with 95% bootstrap intervals. (b) Monotonicity and (c) the information lower bound after template shrinkage of strength γ; dotted lines: predicted Mon_∞.

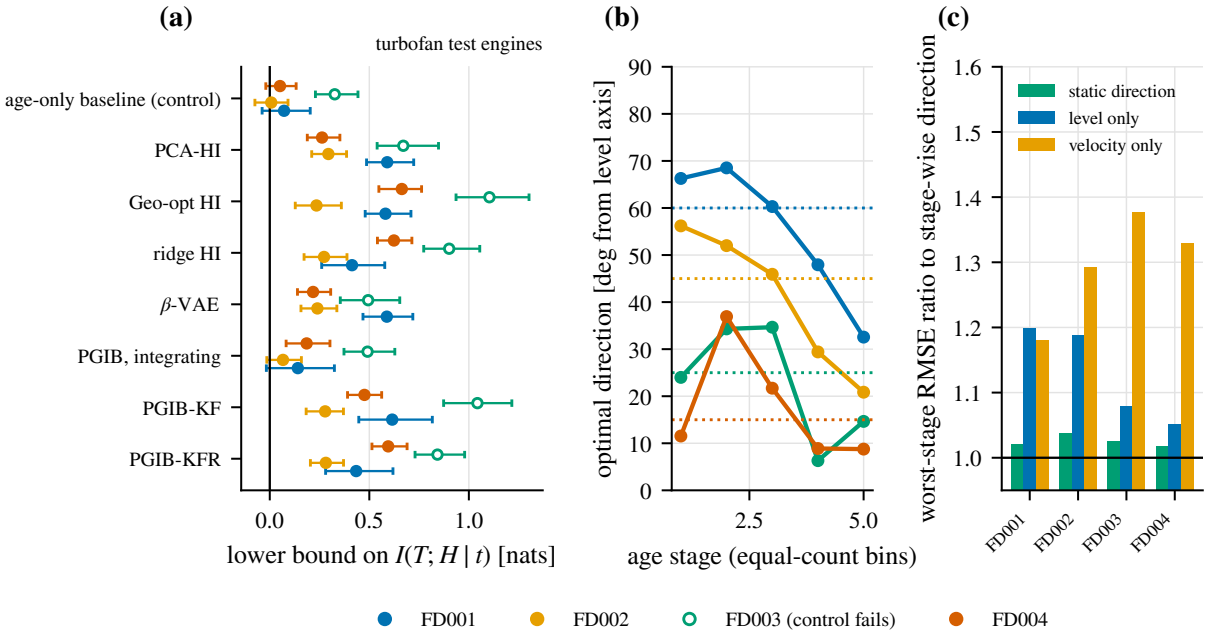


Figure 4: (a) Information lower bounds of the benchmark methods on the official turbofan test engines (hollow markers: age-only control fails). (b) Optimal direction of a scalar linear HI per age stage; dotted: best static direction. (c) Worst-stage RMSE ratio to the direction chosen separately at each stage.

weak (Theorem 1(c)). (ii) An integrating encoder accumulates error and an observation-corrected one does not (Proposition 2). (iii) Learned encoders have a training variance that must be measured before differences between HIs are interpreted.

Design. Three simple HIs (the first principal component, PCA-HI; a combination optimised for the geometric criteria monotonicity, trendability and prognosability, Geo-opt HI; and a supervised ridge regression, ridge HI) are compared with three learned encoders (a β-variational autoencoder, β-VAE; a variational information bottleneck without physics prior, VIB; and the PGIB with its Kalman-corrected variant PGIB-KF and its regime-aware variant PGIB-KFR, Appendix B). All HIs feed the *same* calibrated predictor (Appendix B.3); the *age-only baseline* is that predictor without the HI, that is, the lifetime distribution of the training units conditioned on survival to the current age. The data are battery cells (NASA PCoE, CALCE CS2) and bearings (FEMTO-ST, IMS) with three to seven units each, evaluated leave-one-unit-out, and the four C-MAPSS subsets, evaluated on the official test engines. Appendix C gives the data, the evidence tiers (independent confirmations and development results) and the protocol history; the full tables and the initial protocol are in the Supplementary Material.

Age-only baseline with few training units (prediction i). With two to six training units no method is best everywhere (Supplementary Material): the age-only baseline has the lowest RMSE on both FEMTO conditions and is within a factor of 1.5 of the best method on six of the seven sets. On C-MAPSS the sensors are far more informative: the age-only baseline has an RMSE of 36.6 to 54.7 cycles, against 21.8 to 29.7 for the best simple HI. The age-only baseline is thus a competitive baseline where the sensors are weak, and it must be reported.

Error accumulation and its correction (prediction ii). With 80 to 208 training engines, the integrating encoder performs considerably worse than the best simple HI (single-model RMSE 34.8 to 48.7 against 21.8 to 29.7) and only 2 to 6 RMSE units below the age-only baseline. The observation-corrected PGIB-KF reduces the RMSE to 23.8–40.7 for a single model and to 21.3–35.8 for a ten-seed ensemble (Table 9). The deficit is therefore not caused by the bottleneck objective, which is the same in both models, but by the missing anchoring of the level.

Information lower bounds of the benchmark methods. Using the lifetime distribution of Section 5, the lower bounds on the official test engines (Figure 4(a)) give an information-theoretic reading of the error accumulation of Proposition 2. On FD001, FD002 and FD004 the age-only baseline passes the control (0.07, 0.01 and 0.05 nats). The integrating PGIB reaches only 0.14, 0.07 and 0.19 nats, close to the baseline on FD001 and FD002, whereas PGIB-KF reaches 0.61, 0.28 and 0.48 nats and the best simple HI 0.59, 0.29 and 0.66 nats. On FD003 the control fails (0.33 nats, interval 0.23 to 0.44): the lifetime distribution of the training engines does not describe the test population, and the FD003 values are not interpreted.

Maintenance decision at fixed risk. For each test engine the replacement is scheduled at the predicted RUL plus a margin, the residual quantile of the method that makes 5% (or 10%) of the engines fail; the margin is cross-fitted over engines (five folds, 20 repetitions), and the unused life is the true RUL minus the scheduled time (Appendix F). The age-only baseline leaves 50 to 77 cycles unused (Table 7). The best simple HI, chosen afterwards on each subset, reduces this by 45, 23, 43 and 43% on FD001 to FD004 (intervals above zero), and PGIB-KF leaves 34 to 56 cycles, whereas the integrating PGIB leaves 0 to 12% less than the baseline, with an interval that includes zero on FD001 to FD003. The evaluation is simplified (one decision per engine, no real maintenance costs), but it shows

Table 7: Unused life [cycles] at fixed failure risk on the official test engines (replacement scheduled at the predicted RUL plus a cross-fitted margin that makes 5% or 10% of the engines fail).

	5% of engines fail				10% of engines fail			
Method	FD001	FD002	FD003	FD004	FD001	FD002	FD003	FD004
Age-only baseline	50	54	59	77	44	46	49	67
PCA-HI	28	45	60	74	24	35	44	63
Geo-opt HI	27	42	33	44	24	32	24	34
Ridge HI	36	42	37	49	30	32	29	39
PGIB, integrating	49	53	59	68	42	45	51	62
PGIB-KF	34	46	33	56	25	33	28	45

Table 8: Scalar-HI predictors and an end-to-end predictor on all sensors, official C-MAPSS test engines.

	FD001	FD002	FD003	FD004
RMSE, best of PCA-HI, Geo-opt HI, ridge HI	21.8	28.7	21.9	29.7
RMSE, all sensors, true-RUL target	24.7	26.4	31.6	34.0
RMSE, all sensors, target clipped at 125	13.6	25.1	13.5	26.0
Lower bound [nats], best of the three HIs	0.59	0.29	1.10	0.66
Lower bound [nats], all sensors, clipped target	1.06	0.43	1.59	0.79

that the information quantified by the lower bound translates into usable life, and that the integrating encoder yields little of it.

Comparison with an end-to-end predictor. A gradient-boosting predictor on all 14 sensors (Appendix F) reaches an RMSE of 24.7, 26.4, 31.6 and 34.0 with the true RUL as target and 13.6, 25.1, 13.5 and 26.0 with the target clipped at 125 cycles, against 21.8, 28.7, 21.9 and 29.7 for the best scalar-HI predictor (Table 8). With the unclipped target the scalar HI is better except on FD002; with the clipped target the end-to-end predictor is 38% better on the single-regime subsets and about 12% better on the multi-regime ones. The information lower bound applies to the end-to-end predictor as well, and its excess over the best scalar HI (0.47, 0.14, 0.49 and 0.13 nats; the FD003 values are overestimated because of the lifetime-distribution mismatch) is the information lost by compressing the sensors into one scalar. A scalar HI is therefore justified by interpretability and threshold-based failure models, not by accuracy alone.

Training variability (prediction iii). The RMSE of a single learned encoder has a standard deviation of 1.5 to 7.6 units over seeds, as much as the differences between competing HIs (Table 9), which calls for variance-aware comparisons [57]. A three-seed ensemble on FD003 suggested that PGIB-KF outperforms the best simple HI (19.4 against 21.9), but with ten seeds [33] the difference vanishes (23.3; paired difference $+1.4$, interval -1.6 to 4.5). With ten seeds, PGIB-KF is statistically indistinguishable from the best simple or supervised HI on FD001 to FD003, worse on FD004, and never significantly better. The regime-aware variant is worse than PGIB-KF on the single-regime subsets and better only on FD004, where the difference is not significant.

Effect of the age fusion. The age fusion lowers the RMSE of most HIs and narrows the differences between them; without it the ranking of the learned encoders is less consistent across data sets (Supplementary Material). The conclusion that no learned encoder is superior is therefore stated for the common age-fused predictor.

7. Engineering guidance

This section converts the results into decisions. Table 10 lists the question an engineer faces, the recommendation that follows from the theory, and the size of the effect observed

Table 9: C-MAPSS, ten seeds per learned encoder. Single: RMSE, mean ± standard deviation over seeds; ens. 10: ten-seed ensemble; the best simple HI includes the regime-specific ridge regression; last column: paired difference of PGIB-KF from the best simple HI with 95% bootstrap interval over engines [58].

Subset	Best simple HI (RMSE)	PGIB-HI single	PGIB-KF-HI single	PGIB-KFR-HI single	PGIB-KF-HI ens. 10	PGIB-KFR-HI ens. 10	KF − best paired, ens. 10 [95% CI]	KFR − best
FD001	PCA (21.8)	34.8±2.9	23.8±3.3	27.5±3.2	21.3	25.5	-0.6 [-3.2, +2.5]	+3.6 [+0.2, +7.0]
FD002	regime ridge (28.4)	36.3±1.5	31.0±2.2	30.6±2.2	29.2	29.1	+0.8 [-0.7, +2.3]	+0.7 [-1.2, +2.8]
FD003	Geo-opt. (21.9)	41.2±1.9	30.1±4.6	33.8±6.5	23.3	28.4	+1.4 [-1.6, +4.5]	+6.5 [+2.4, +10.6]
FD004	Geo-opt. (29.7)	48.7±2.5	40.7±7.6	36.8±4.0	35.8	31.8	+6.1 [+2.5, +9.7]	+2.1 [-0.9, +5.0]

in Sections 5 and 6.

Workflow. The recommendations combine into four steps. (1) Fit the age-only baseline and compute its information lower bound, which must not exceed zero. (2) Build candidate HIs from sensors normalised by regime or by the unit's early cycles, and provide their level and velocity to the predictor. (3) Compute the age-conditional information lower bound of each candidate by unit-grouped cross-validation with bootstrap intervals over units, and keep the HI with the highest information lower bound whose interval excludes zero. (4) Under a fitted Wiener degradation model, compare the achieved RMSE with the aleatoric floor to judge how much a better HI could still gain. The bound requires about 40 run-to-failure units (Section 5.8); with fewer than 10 units the age-only baseline and the simplest HI are the recommended choice.

8. Limitations and conclusions

Limitations.

1. *Theory.* The theory of Section 4.2 is local and Gaussian, Theorem 2 assumes a constant-drift Wiener future, Proposition 1 concerns a scalar sensor and a regime-blind linear estimator, and Theorem 4 concerns scalar linear HIs with fixed weights. Non-Gaussian posteriors, non-constant drift, regime switching and nonlinear multi-sensor estimators are open, and the entropy estimates of the simulations have a Monte Carlo error of about 5% (Section 3). The formal results are elementary consequences of the data processing inequality, Gaussian conditioning and linear recursions; their value lies in what they let an engineer measure and decide.
2. *Information lower bounds.* The efficiency η_{info} could not be estimated reliably on real data. It depends on the predictor and, in its age-conditional form, on a lifetime distribution that must be validated by a negative control, which failed for the test population of FD003. It is uninformative for most small data sets, where a positive lower bound on the information that an HI adds to the age could not be established (Section 5).
3. *Benchmark design.* The regime-aware variant and the variance study were designed after seeing results on the sets used, and no independent multi-regime data set was available (evidence tiers in Appendix C). Ensembles of ten encoders are compared with deterministic simple HIs, which favours the encoders in computation. The age fusion and the out-of-sample calibration were introduced after an initial protocol showed under-coverage; they benefit most HIs but are a heuristic procedure, not a Bayes-exact fusion, and they obscure part of the differences between HIs.

Table 10: Engineering guidance: decisions in HI design, recommendations and the effects observed.

Question	Recommendation	Effect observed
Does my HI keep the information a predictor needs?	Compute the age-conditional information lower bound (Theorem 1(c)) by unit-grouped cross-validation, with the age-only predictor as negative control; the gain over the control is the logarithm of the RMSE ratio, so 0.1 nat is an RMSE lower by about 10%.	Lower bound of the ridge HI 0.10 to 0.60 nats with the control at or below 0.05 nats; the control failed on FD003 and on four of the seven small sets; subsets of 40 units gave a valid result in 70 to 100% of the draws, except on Tongji.
Which HI should I keep?	Use monotonicity, trendability and prognosability as screening scores, not as evidence of information; confirm the chosen HI by its information lower bound.	Template shrinkage raised the monotonicity from 0.13–0.24 to 0.41–0.58 on engines while the lower bound fell to about zero. Over 42 candidate HIs the Spearman correlation of the geometric score with the lower bound was 0.64–0.97 on engines and 0.08–0.74 on cells.
One scalar, or level and velocity?	Give the predictor the level and the velocity of the HI, or let the weights follow the stage of life.	A static direction increased the RMSE by at most 4% on engines, 1.2% on MATR, 7% on Tongji and 9 to 18% on HUST; level alone or velocity alone increased it by up to 35% and 54%.
Do operating regimes or test protocols matter?	Normalise the sensors by regime and, when protocols differ, by each unit's own early cycles; give the regime to the observation model when gains differ.	Without normalisation the RMSE of a linear estimator was higher by 8% (FD002), 21% (FD004), 18% (HUST), 26% (MATR) and 14% (Tongji).
Should an encoder integrate the velocity?	Not without an observation correction, that is, a learned gain on a direct level estimate.	RMSE on C-MAPSS: integrating encoder 34.8 to 48.7; corrected encoder 23.8 to 40.7 (single model) and 21.3 to 35.8 (ten-seed ensemble).
Does the information become maintenance value?	Evaluate the unused life at a fixed failure risk, not only the RMSE.	At 5% failing engines the best simple HI left 23 to 45% less life unused than the age-only baseline (50 to 77 cycles); the integrating encoder 0 to 12% less.
Is a scalar HI needed, and is a learned encoder justified?	Compare the information lower bound of the HI with that of a predictor on all sensors; keep a scalar HI for interpretability and threshold-based failure models, and adopt a learned encoder only if its information lower bound is higher than that of a simple HI under the same age-fused predictor.	Compression into one scalar lost 0.13 to 0.49 nats on engines and 0.29 to 0.37 nats on cells; no learned encoder outperformed the best simple HI; the age-only baseline was within a factor of 1.5 of the best on six of seven small sets.
How much can a better HI still gain?	Under a fitted Wiener model, compare the achieved error with the aleatoric floor of Theorem 2.	In the simulated example 42% of the squared error of a lossless HI is irreducible.

4. *Data.* The bearing features are generic time-domain and spectral summaries, and physics-based features may change the conclusions. The battery and bearing sets of the benchmark have three to seven units, and the C-MAPSS benchmark is evaluated at the last observed cycle of each test engine. The real-data tests use cross-validation within the data sets and cover simulated turbofan engines and three collections of

lithium-ion cells with charging-phase features. They include no bearing data set with more than a few units because, to our knowledge, no public run-to-failure bearing collection has more than 17 bearings (FEMTO-ST and the Paderborn time-varying set have 17, XJTU-SY has 15; a survey of 110 public data sets lists seven for bearing prognosis [59]). Right-censored units are not handled; the 33 Tongji cells that never reached the end-of-life threshold were excluded, which biases the lifetime distribution toward shorter-lived cells (Section 5). The information lower bound needs run-to-failure units, which are rare in field practice, and the subset experiment draws from the same data sets, not from independent fleets.

5. *Scope.* The paper does not claim that a scalar HI is needed for accuracy: an end-to-end predictor on all sensors is considerably more accurate on the single-regime engines (Section 6), and a comparison with deep end-to-end models was not made. The maintenance-decision evaluation is simplified: one decision per engine, a margin cross-fitted over the test engines and no real maintenance costs, and no field data were available.

Conclusions. For any HI, an engineer can ask how much information about the RUL it retains beyond the age, and the answer, in nats, follows from the held-out error of any predictor. The theory identifies four ways in which an HI loses information, and the tests on turbofan engines and lithium-ion cells show that they matter in practice. Monotonicity scores can rise while information vanishes; a static scalar HI increases the RMSE by up to 18% in one cell collection; ignoring the operating regime or protocol raises the error of a linear estimator by 8 to 26%; and an integrating encoder needs an observation correction. With fewer than about 40 units the age-only baseline is competitive, and no learned encoder outperformed simple indicators. The contribution of the paper is the budget and the decisions it supports, not a new predictor.

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Data availability

NASA PCoE, NASA IMS, C-MAPSS, CALCE CS2, FEMTO-ST/PRONOSTIA, HUST, MATR and Tongji data are publicly available (NASA Prognostics Data Repository, CALCE Battery Group, IEEE 2012 Prognostics and Health Management data challenge, BatteryLife repository on Zenodo). The code, the stored results and the per-unit outputs used to generate all tables and figures, and a Python package for computing the information lower bound on new data are available at `https://github.com/HuyHoangLe0201/information-budget-health-indicator-rul`. The Supplementary Material gives the learned encoders, the benchmark protocols, the detailed benchmark tables and the initial protocol.

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A. Proofs and supplementary results

A.1. Relation to the Bayesian Cramér–Rao bound

Remark 3 (Relation to the Bayesian Cramér–Rao bound)**.** *Let $J(\mathsf{h})$ be the Fisher information, with respect to location, of the posterior density $p(T_t \mid H_{1:t} = \mathsf{h})$. Under the regularity conditions of the van Trees inequality [43, 44] every estimator satisfies $\mathbb{E}[(T_t - \hat{T}_t)^2] \geq 1/\mathbb{E}_H[J(H)]$. Stam's inequality [60] states that $e^{2h(T_t|H=\mathsf{h})}/(2\pi e) \geq 1/J(\mathsf{h})$ for every h. Taking the geometric mean over h and using that the geometric mean of $1/J$ is at least the reciprocal of the arithmetic mean of J,*

$$\mathcal{B}_{\text{info}}(H_{1:t}) = \exp\Big(\mathbb{E}_H \ln \frac{e^{2h(T_t|H=\mathsf{h})}}{2\pi e}\Big) \;\geq\; \exp\Big(\mathbb{E}_H \ln \frac{1}{J(H)}\Big) \;\geq\; \frac{1}{\mathbb{E}_H[J(H)]}, \tag{A.1}$$

so, wherever the Bayesian Cramér–Rao bound applies, the entropy-power bound is not weaker, and it requires no differentiability of the densities. For posterior filtering the Fisher-information route is developed in [45].

A.2. State–kinematic decomposition and pointwise shrinkage

Proposition 3 (State–kinematic decomposition)**.** *Let $\Delta H_k = H_k - H_{k-1}$ denote the increments of the HI. The map $H_{1:t} \mapsto (H_t, \Delta H_{2:t})$ is a linear bijection, hence*

$$I(T_t; H_{1:t}) = \underbrace{I(T_t; H_t)}_{\mathcal{I}_{\text{state}}(t)} + \underbrace{I(T_t; \Delta H_{2:t} \mid H_t)}_{\mathcal{I}_{\text{kin}}(t)}. \tag{A.2}$$

Proof. The map has a unit-determinant matrix, so $h(\mathbf{AY}) = h(\mathbf{Y}) + \ln|\det \mathbf{A}|$ [35, Sect. 8.6] and mutual information is unchanged ($H_k = H_t - \sum_{j=k+1}^{t} \Delta H_j$ gives the inverse). The identity is then the chain rule of mutual information [35, Sect. 2.5]. □

Remark 4. *The decomposition is an identity; its content lies in which operations remove which part. If the HI is the noise-free level of a process with constant drift started at zero, H_t/t is a sufficient statistic for the drift, and $\mathcal{I}_{\text{kin}}$ about the drift is zero. Kinematic information is non-trivial when the velocity varies in time, for example under a state-dependent drift or a random-walk velocity, as in late-life acceleration.*

Proposition 4 (Pointwise shrinkage)**.** *Let the shrinkage of Theorem 3 act pointwise in time, $\tilde{H}_k = \phi_k(H_k, \xi_k)$. Then*

$$\begin{gathered} \ln \frac{\mathcal{B}_{\text{info}}(\tilde{H}_{1:t})}{\mathcal{B}_{\text{info}}(H_{1:t})} = 2\big(\Delta\mathcal{I}_{\text{state}} + \Delta\mathcal{I}_{\text{kin}}\big), \\ \Delta\mathcal{I}_{\text{state}} := \mathcal{I}_{\text{state}}(H) - \mathcal{I}_{\text{state}}(\tilde{H}) \geq 0, \quad \Delta\mathcal{I}_{\text{kin}} := \mathcal{I}_{\text{kin}}(H) - \mathcal{I}_{\text{kin}}(\tilde{H}), \end{gathered} \tag{A.3}$$

where $\Delta\mathcal{I}_{\text{kin}}$ has no definite sign in general, so that kinematic information alone does not determine the increase of the bound. In the Gaussian shrinkage of Theorem 3(b), write $\mathcal{I}^{\vartheta}_{\text{state}}(\gamma) = I(\vartheta; \tilde{H}^{\gamma}_t)$ and $\mathcal{I}^{\vartheta}_{\text{kin}}(\gamma) = I(\vartheta; \Delta\tilde{H}^{\gamma}_{2:t} \mid \tilde{H}^{\gamma}_t)$; then $\mathcal{I}^{\vartheta}_{\text{state}}$ is non-increasing in γ and $0 \leq \mathcal{I}^{\vartheta}_{\text{state}}, \mathcal{I}^{\vartheta}_{\text{kin}} \leq \mathcal{I}^{\vartheta}_{\text{tot}}(\gamma) \to 0$, although $\mathcal{I}^{\vartheta}_{\text{kin}}$ need not be monotone.

Proof. Apply Proposition 3 to H and to $\tilde{H}$ and take the difference in Theorem 3(a). Because $\tilde{H}_t = \phi_t(H_t, \xi_t)$ is a randomised function of H_t alone, the DPI gives $I(T_t; \tilde{H}_t) \leq I(T_t; H_t)$, that is, $\Delta\mathcal{I}_{\text{state}} \geq 0$. For non-pointwise operators (for example smoothing over history) even this sign can fail. In the Gaussian shrinkage, the argument of the proof of Theorem 3(b) applied to the scalar observation at time t gives the monotonicity of $\mathcal{I}^{\vartheta}_{\text{state}}$; since $\mathcal{I}^{\vartheta}_{\text{state}} = I(\vartheta; \tilde{H}_t) \leq I(\vartheta; \tilde{H}_{1:t})$ and $\mathcal{I}^{\vartheta}_{\text{kin}} = \mathcal{I}^{\vartheta}_{\text{tot}} - \mathcal{I}^{\vartheta}_{\text{state}} \leq \mathcal{I}^{\vartheta}_{\text{tot}}$, both are dominated by $\mathcal{I}^{\vartheta}_{\text{tot}}$, which vanishes as $\gamma \to 1$. □

A.3. Proof of Theorem 3

Proof. (a) $\tilde{H}$ is a randomised function of H only, so the Markov property holds and the DPI gives the first claim; the ratio follows from the definition of $\mathcal{B}_{\text{info}}$. (b) With $\lambda = 1 - \gamma > 0$, $\tilde{H}^{\gamma}$ is an invertible affine image of $(H - m) + \xi^{(2)}/\lambda$, that is, of H observed through additive Gaussian noise of variance σ_2^2/λ^2. For $\gamma_2 > \gamma_1$ the noise of the second channel is the first plus independent Gaussian noise, so the DPI [35, Sect. 2.8] gives monotonicity of $\mathcal{I}_{\text{tot}}^{\vartheta}$. As $\lambda \to 0$ the noise variance diverges; in a linear-Gaussian channel $I(\vartheta; Y) = \frac{1}{2} \ln\big(\operatorname{Var}(\vartheta)/\operatorname{Var}(\vartheta \mid Y)\big)$ [35, Chap. 9] and $\operatorname{Var}(\vartheta \mid Y) \to \operatorname{Var}(\vartheta)$, so the information vanishes. For the limit of Mon, as $\lambda \to 0$ at fixed t the increments converge to $\Delta m + \xi_{k+1}^{(2)} - \xi_k^{(2)}$, a stationary 1-dependent sequence. The indicators of a positive increment at odd k involve disjoint pairs of the $\xi^{(2)}$ and are therefore i.i.d., as are those at even k, so the strong law of large numbers [61, Chap. 2] applies to each subsequence and the fraction of positive increments tends to $p = \Phi_{\mathcal{N}}(\Delta m/(\sqrt{2}\sigma_2))$ and, letting $t \to \infty$, Mon $\to |2p - 1|$. □

A.4. Non-Gaussianity gap

Proposition 5 (Non-Gaussianity gap)**.** *Let $\hat{m}_H = \mathbb{E}[m \mid H]$ be the Bayes-optimal estimator of m and let $D_{\mathsf{h}} := D_{\mathrm{KL}}\big(p(m \mid H = \mathsf{h}) \,\|\, \mathcal{N}(\mathbb{E}[m \mid H = \mathsf{h}], \operatorname{Var}(m \mid H = \mathsf{h}))\big) \geq 0$ be the Kullback–Leibler (KL) divergence of the posterior from the Gaussian with the same mean and variance. Then*

$$\mathbb{E}\big[(m - \hat{m}_H)^2\big] - \mathbb{E}_H\left[\frac{e^{2h(m|H=\mathsf{h})}}{2\pi e}\right] = \mathbb{E}_H\Big[\operatorname{Var}(m \mid H)\big(1 - e^{-2D_H}\big)\Big] \;\geq 0, \tag{A.4}$$

with equality if and only if $p(m \mid H)$ is Gaussian almost surely.

Proof. For a density p with mean μ_p and variance σ_p^2 and the Gaussian $q = \mathcal{N}(\mu_p, \sigma_p^2)$, $\int p \ln q = -\frac{1}{2}\ln(2\pi\sigma_p^2) - \frac{1}{2}$ because q depends on x only through the first two moments of p. Hence $D_{\mathrm{KL}}(p\|q) = -h(p) + \frac{1}{2}\ln(2\pi e\sigma_p^2)$ (the identity behind the maximum-entropy property of the Gaussian [35, Sect. 8.6]), that is, $e^{2h(p)}/(2\pi e) = \sigma_p^2 e^{-2D_{\mathrm{KL}}(p\|q)}$. Apply this to $p = p(m \mid H = \mathsf{h})$, use $\mathbb{E}[(m - \hat{m}_H)^2 \mid H = \mathsf{h}] = \operatorname{Var}(m \mid H = \mathsf{h})$, which holds because the posterior mean is the Bayes-optimal estimator under squared loss [49, Sect. 1.5.5], and average over h. The right-hand side vanishes if and only if $D_H = 0$ almost surely, that is, if and only if the posterior is Gaussian. □

A.5. Reduction to functionals of the sufficient statistic

Lemma 1 (Reduction to functionals of $\hat{\mathbf{z}}$)**.** *For every scalar linear functional $w^{\top}\mathbf{X}_{1:t}$ there is $\mathbf{u}$ such that $\operatorname{corr}(m_L, w^{\top}\mathbf{X})^2 \leq \operatorname{corr}(m_L, \mathbf{u}^{\top}\hat{\mathbf{z}})^2$. Hence no scalar linear HI is more informative about m_L than the best $h_{\mathbf{u}}$, because in a Gaussian model $I = -\frac{1}{2}\ln(1 - \operatorname{corr}^2)$. Here* corr *denotes the correlation coefficient.*

Proof. Let $\mathbf{C} = \operatorname{Cov}(\mathbf{z}, \mathbf{X})$ and $\mathbf{V} = \operatorname{Var}(\mathbf{X})$, so $\hat{\mathbf{z}} = \mathbf{z}_0 + \mathbf{C}\mathbf{V}^{-1}(\mathbf{X} - \mathbb{E}\mathbf{X})$ and $\mathbf{\Lambda} = \mathbf{C}\mathbf{V}^{-1}\mathbf{C}^{\top}$. Put $\mathbf{u} = \mathbf{\Lambda}^{-1}\mathbf{C}w$. Then $\operatorname{Cov}(\hat{\mathbf{z}}, w^{\top}\mathbf{X}) = \mathbf{C}\mathbf{V}^{-1}\mathbf{V}w = \mathbf{C}w = \mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{u}$, so $w^{\top}\mathbf{X} = \mathbf{u}^{\top}\hat{\mathbf{z}} + e$ with e uncorrelated with $\hat{\mathbf{z}}$ and, since $\operatorname{Cov}(\mathbf{z}, w^{\top}\mathbf{X}) = \mathbf{C}w = \mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{u} = \operatorname{Cov}(\mathbf{z}, \mathbf{u}^{\top}\hat{\mathbf{z}})$, also uncorrelated with $\mathbf{z}$. Therefore $\operatorname{Cov}(m_L, w^{\top}\mathbf{X}) = \operatorname{Cov}(m_L, \mathbf{u}^{\top}\hat{\mathbf{z}}) = \mathbf{g}^{\top}\mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{u}$ while $\operatorname{Var}(w^{\top}\mathbf{X}) = \mathbf{u}^{\top}\mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{u} + \operatorname{Var}(e) \geq \operatorname{Var}(\mathbf{u}^{\top}\hat{\mathbf{z}})$, which gives the claim. □

A.6. Proof of Corollary 1

Proof. (a) By Theorem 4, the gradient of the frozen-velocity RUL at the operating point is $\mathbf{g} = -\bar{V}^{-1}(1, \bar{a}/\bar{V})^\top$, which is proportional to $(1, \bar{\tau})^\top$; the Euclidean angle of this direction from the level axis is $\arctan \bar{\tau}$. (b) By Theorem 4(c), the increase of the bound at stage j vanishes only for $\mathbf{u} \parallel \mathbf{g}_j$, so it vanishes at both stages only if $\mathbf{g}_1 \parallel \mathbf{g}_2$. The map $\mathbf{u} \mapsto \max_j \rho_j \sin^2 \psi_j(\mathbf{u})$ is continuous and positive on the unit circle, hence has a positive minimum δ. For the quantitative statement note that the $\mathbf{\Lambda}$-angle between lines satisfies the triangle inequality $\psi_{12} \le \psi_1 + \psi_2$. Indeed, for unit vectors a, b in the $\mathbf{\Lambda}$-inner product the angle $\arccos\langle a, b\rangle$ is the geodesic distance on the unit sphere, which is a metric, and the angle between the lines through a and b is $\min_{s=\pm 1} \arccos\langle a, sb\rangle$. Choose the sign of the representative of $\mathbf{u}$ so that its angle to the representative of $\mathbf{g}_1$ is ψ_1, then the sign of the representative of $\mathbf{g}_2$ so that its angle to that of $\mathbf{u}$ is ψ_2; the spherical triangle inequality bounds the angle between the representatives of $\mathbf{g}_1$ and $\mathbf{g}_2$ by $\psi_1 + \psi_2$, and ψ_{12} is not larger. Therefore $\max_j \psi_j \ge \psi_{12}/2$ and $\sin^2$ is increasing on $[0, \pi/2]$. The last sentence is Theorem 4(c) applied at each stage. □

B. Estimators used in the benchmark

This appendix describes the estimators compared in Section 6. The path-space objective follows from the theory; the architectures and the calibration are design choices.

We use a causal stochastic encoder, the *physics-guided information bottleneck* (PGIB), whose HI increments are Gaussian, $\mathcal{N}\big(H_{k-1} + u_\theta \Delta t,\ s_\theta^2 \Delta t\big)$ with a positive velocity u_θ, regularised towards a physics prior with state-dependent drift and diffusion coefficient σ_B. The training objective is $\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{FHT}} + \beta D_{\mathrm{KL}}$: the negative log-likelihood of the observed failure time under the predictive distribution below, plus β times the path-space Kullback–Leibler divergence of the encoder from the prior, which is a variational upper bound of $I(\mathbf{X}_{1:t}; H_{1:t})$ [36–38] and has a closed form for Gaussian transitions (Supplementary Material).

B.1. Predictive distribution

Let the posterior of the unit's drift μ given the HI increments be $\mathcal{N}(\hat{\mu}_t, \sigma_{\mu,t}^2)$ (conjugate update). Marginalising the inverse-Gaussian distribution over μ (a Gaussian integral; random-drift Wiener models are treated in [26, 27]) gives

$$p(T_t = \tau \mid H_{1:t}) = \frac{a}{\sqrt{2\pi\tau^3(\sigma_B^2 + \sigma_{\mu,t}^2\tau)}} \exp\!\left(-\frac{(a - \hat{\mu}_t\tau)^2}{2\tau(\sigma_B^2 + \sigma_{\mu,t}^2\tau)}\right), \qquad a = D_{\mathrm{fail}} - \hat{D}_t. \tag{B.1}$$

Here σ_B^2 is the aleatoric and $\sigma_{\mu,t}^2\tau$ the epistemic contribution to the effective diffusion; as t grows $\sigma_{\mu,t}^2 \to 0$ and (B.1) reduces to the inverse-Gaussian distribution. It is a defective density, the missing mass being the probability that the threshold is never reached, which can happen only for a non-positive drift, and $\hat{D}_t$ is the filtered state rather than the raw HI value, which avoids the degeneracies of non-monotone paths. The distribution was checked against numerical integration of the mixture (Section 3).

B.2. Observation-corrected and regime-aware encoders

The encoder above integrates a positive velocity, so nothing anchors the level to the observations (Section 4.4). The observation-corrected encoder, PGIB-KF (KF: Kalman

filter), adds a direct level estimate $l_k = f_l(\mathbf{h}_k)$ and a learned gain $\omega_k = \mathrm{sig}(f_\omega(\mathbf{h}_k)) \in (0,1)$ to the encoder features $\mathbf{h}_k$ (sig is the logistic function, $\epsilon_k \sim \mathcal{N}(0,1)$ the encoder noise),

$$H_k = (1-\omega_k)\big(H_{k-1} + u_k + s_k\epsilon_k\big) + \omega_k\, l_k. \tag{B.2}$$

Given H_{k-1} this is again a Gaussian transition, with drift $(1-\omega_k)u_k + \omega_k(l_k - H_{k-1})$ and standard deviation $(1-\omega_k)s_k$, so the path-space divergence keeps its closed form; $\beta \to \infty$ gives $\omega \to 0$, a pure integrator. The regime-aware variant PGIB-KFR (Proposition 1) uses regime-specific linear heads for l_k and ω_k; with a single regime it reduces to PGIB-KF.

B.3. Calibrated predictive distribution with age fusion

Because the age is always known (Theorem 1(c)), the HI-based distribution $p_{\mathrm{HI}}(\tau)$, which is (B.1) with diffusion $c\,v_t$ and drift variance $c\,v_t/w_t$ (v_t is the variance of the HI increments over a trailing window of length w_t, or the learned σ_B^2 for the bottleneck models, and $c > 0$ a calibration multiplier), is pooled log-linearly [62, 63] with the age-based distribution $p_{\mathrm{age}}(\tau \mid t) = f_L(t+\tau)/S_L(t)$, the log-normal lifetime density f_L with survival function S_L [64] of the training lifetimes, conditioned on survival to age t:

$$p(\tau) \;\propto\; p_{\mathrm{HI}}(\tau)^{w_{\mathrm{h}}}\, p_{\mathrm{age}}(\tau \mid t)^{w_{\mathrm{a}}}, \qquad (c, w_{\mathrm{h}}, w_{\mathrm{a}}) \in \mathcal{G}, \tag{B.3}$$

on a finite grid $\mathcal{G}$ that includes the plain HI distribution $(1,0)$ and the age-only distribution $(0,1)$. The parameters minimise the negative log-likelihood of the true RUL, a strictly proper scoring rule [65], on HI paths produced *out of sample* (each HI construction is fitted on all but one training unit and applied to the left-out unit; the test unit is never used). The pooling is a calibration procedure, not a Bayes-exact fusion. The same predictor is used for every HI.

C. Benchmark data and evidence tiers

Data. Public run-to-failure collections were used: NASA PCoE cells B0005, B0006, B0007 and B0018 [66]; CALCE CS2 cells (four cells CS2_35 to CS2_38, and a six-cell set with the protocol-heterogeneous cells CS2_33 and CS2_34) [67]; the FEMTO-ST/PRONOSTIA bearings of conditions 1 to 3 (seven, seven and three units) [68]; the NASA IMS bearings (four units that failed) [69, 70]; and the C-MAPSS turbofan engines FD001 to FD004 [71]. For batteries the capacity only defines the end of life (the first cycle at which the rolling-median capacity falls to 75% for NASA or 80% for CALCE of the initial capacity) and is never an input; for bearings the end of life is the last snapshot. Inclusion rules were fixed before running any model (scripts and outputs are supplied). Evaluation is leave-one-unit-out for the small sets (metrics in the window 40–90% of life, pooled over the held-out units) and uses the official test engines for C-MAPSS, with the training engines split by identifier into fitting and calibration engines.

Methods. To isolate the effect of HI construction, every HI is mapped affinely to 0 at the start and 1 at the end of life with the *training* units only, and passed to the same calibrated predictor of Appendix B.3; the standardisation, the PCA direction, the weights of the Geo-opt HI (differential evolution), the encoders and the affine map are all fitted on the training units and applied unchanged to the test unit. The parameters $(c, w_{\mathrm{h}}, w_{\mathrm{a}})$ are chosen on HI paths that are out of sample for the HI construction. For the bottleneck models the compression weight $\beta \in \{0.03, 0.3, 3, 30\}$ and the encoder are selected by validation on training units only. All details are in the Supplementary Material.

Table D.11: Age-conditional information lower bound (nats) under a fitted log-normal lifetime model; $\bar{h}(T \mid t)$: mean conditional entropy. A positive value for the age-only predictor shows that the model overestimates $h(T \mid t)$.

Data set	$\bar{h}(T \mid t)$	Age-only	PCA	Geo-opt.	β-VAE	VIB	PGIB
NASA	4.67	-0.28	0.04	0.07	-0.14	-0.23	-0.29
CALCE-4	5.74	0.49	0.39	0.56	0.42	0.46	0.68
CALCE-6	5.69	0.35	0.23	0.44	-0.05	0.31	0.38
FEMTO-1	7.81	0.19	-0.28	0.11	-0.15	-0.03	0.11
FEMTO-2	7.77	0.29	0.03	0.13	0.08	0.25	0.24
FEMTO-3	7.30	-0.45	-0.35	-0.46	-0.19	-0.34	-0.35
IMS	8.65	-0.20	0.62	0.39	-0.58	-0.31	-0.16

Protocol history and evidence tiers. The study proceeded in five protocols, which determine how the numbers can be read. P1 showed that the integrating encoder under-covers and that the age-only baseline is competitive. P2 added out-of-sample calibration, age fusion and a prediction grid independent of the test unit; it was frozen, with the file hash recorded, before it was run on the confirmation sets (FEMTO condition 3 and IMS). On C-MAPSS FD001, P2 showed that the integrating encoder is considerably worse than simple HIs even with 80 training engines. The diagnosis of Proposition 2 led to P3, the observation-corrected PGIB-KF, which was frozen and run once on FD003, a subset not used before, and then, with regime-wise preprocessing, once on FD002 and FD004. P4 added the regime-aware encoder and a regime-specific ridge baseline and was run once on each subset, the choice between PGIB-KF and PGIB-KFR and of β being made on the calibration engines only; FD002 and FD004 are therefore development sets for P4, and no independent multi-regime data set was available (the successor N-CMAPSS has only six to ten units per subset). Because the differences between learned encoders and simple HIs were of the size of the seed-to-seed variability, P5 retrained the learned encoders on the four subsets with ten fresh seeds, keeping architecture, β and calibration fixed; it supersedes the three-seed results where they disagree. The evidence tiers are: (i) *independent confirmation*: C-MAPSS FD003, FD002 and FD004 for P3 (not for P4), and FEMTO condition 3 and IMS for P2 (not for P3); (ii) *development*: NASA, CALCE (four and six cells), FEMTO conditions 1 and 2 and C-MAPSS FD001, which informed the design and whose results are therefore not unbiased estimates of out-of-sample performance.

D. Information lower bound on the small data sets

Table D.11 gives the model-based age-conditional information lower bound of the seven small battery and bearing sets under a fitted log-normal lifetime distribution (Section 5.2).

E. Efficiency estimation on real data

A direct estimate of $I(T; H)$ with the Kraskov–Stögbauer–Grassberger estimator [40] on rank-transformed window summaries gave, for several HIs, values above the estimate for the 12-dimensional raw sensor summary, which is impossible for a true mutual information because the summary contains the HI. This reflects the bias of the estimator in 12 dimensions at a few hundred samples, a known limitation [41, 42]. A simulation with known mutual information (twelve Gaussian sensor features, a scalar target and a scalar HI with $\eta_{\text{info}} = 0.7$) shows that the estimator underestimates $I(T; \mathbf{X})$ strongly, so that

$\hat{\eta}_{\text{info}}$ exceeds 1 in every replication even with 3000 samples. We therefore do not report η_{info} on real data. The information lower bound of Theorem 1(b) avoids high-dimensional estimation.

F. Details of the real-data tests

Turbofan engines: set-up. Each subset uses its training engines (run to failure); the 14 informative sensors are standardised with the training engines of the fold, within regime for FD002 and FD004 (six regimes from k-means clustering of the operating settings). The ridge HI is a ridge regression (penalty 10) of the life fraction on the standardised sensors, smoothed by a trailing mean of 5 cycles and mapped affinely to zero at the start and one at the end of life with the training engines of the fold; PCA-HI is the first principal component. The trajectory summary of an HI consists of its trailing mean over 10 cycles (level), its least-squares slope over the last 30 cycles (velocity), its values 20 and 50 cycles earlier, and the age; the raw-sensor predictor uses level and slope of every sensor and the age. Predictors are histogram-based gradient-boosted regression trees (200 iterations, learning rate 0.08, 31 leaves, at least 40 samples per leaf, L_2 penalty 1) trained on all pairs of the training engines of a fold. The lifetime distribution is estimated by a Gaussian kernel density of $\ln L$ (Scott bandwidth) of the training engines of the fold; the conditional density of the RUL at age t is $f_L(t+\tau)/S_L(t)$ and $h(T_t \mid t)$ is evaluated numerically on a grid of 0.5 cycles. Bootstrap intervals resample engines (300 replicates).

Lithium-ion cells. Each cycle of the processed records yields the discharge capacity, the charge duration (samples with current above 0.01 A) and the charge voltage when the charged capacity first reaches 27% and 73% of the nominal capacity; the HIs use the last three quantities. The charge duration is divided by its mean over cycles 2 to 11 of the same cell and the voltages are reduced by their means over these cycles, and the result is standardised with the training cells of the fold. Time scales are set by the lifetimes. For HUST the minimum age is 100 cycles, ages are sampled every 5 cycles, the windows are 20 cycles (level) and 100 cycles (velocity), the lags are 100 and 250 cycles and the grid of the conditional entropy has a step of 2 cycles. For MATR the corresponding values are 50, 3, 10, 50, 50 and 125 cycles and a step of 1 cycle. The trees have at most 15 leaves, and all other settings are those of the engines. The capacity reference uses level and velocity of the relative discharge capacity and the age. The end of life is the first cycle at which the running median of the discharge capacity over 5 cycles falls below 80% of the mean over the first 5 cycles (HUST), or the life label of the source, at which the recordings end (MATR; recordings that end more than 10 cycles before the label would be excluded, and none was). For Tongji the minimum age is 30 cycles, ages are sampled every 2 cycles, the windows are 10 and 40 cycles, the lags 40 and 100 cycles and the step 1 cycle, and the end of life is the first cycle at which the running median of the discharge capacity falls below 80% of the nominal capacity; cells that do not reach it, or reach it within 100 cycles, are excluded. The capacity levels of the charge-voltage and discharge-voltage features are 3/11 and 8/11 of the nominal capacity. The processed records are unpickled with a restricted reader that admits only array types. The protocol analysis of Section 5 uses the three charging features standardised over the population (blind) or relative to the own cycles 2 to 11 (normalised), with the ridge regression of the engines.

Table F.12: Tongji: main analysis (88 cells) and sensitivity to the inclusion rule (119 cells, cells that never reached the threshold counted as failed at their last recorded cycle).

	Main (88 cells)	All cells (119 cells)
Age-only control [nats]	0.05 [-0.04, 0.15]	-0.04 [-0.09, 0.03]
Ridge HI lower bound [nats]	0.60 [0.47, 0.76]	0.31 [0.23, 0.43]
Charging features [nats]	0.91	0.48
Monotonicity: $\gamma = 0$, 0.995 (predicted)	0.65, 0.73 (0.70)	0.63, 0.72 (0.68)
Lower bound after shrinkage, $\gamma = 0.995$ [nats]	-0.00	-0.14
Worst-stage RMSE ratio, static / free	1.068	1.094
Protocol-blind / normalised estimator RMSE	0.190 / 0.167	0.188 / 0.179

Additional analyses. Candidate HIs. For each data set, 40 weight vectors with independent standard normal entries (signed so that the HI increases with age on the training units) are applied to the normalised sensors (engines) or charging features (cells), together with the PCA-HI and the ridge HI; each HI is smoothed over 5 cycles and mapped affinely to zero at the start and one at the end of life with the training units of the fold. The information lower bound is computed as in the main analysis (ages sampled every 3 cycles for engines), and the geometric score is the sum of the monotonicity, the trendability (absolute correlation with time, averaged over units) and the prognosability on the held-out units; the Spearman correlation is taken over the 42 HIs. *Decision evaluation.* The predictions of the age-only baseline, PCA-HI, Geo-opt HI, ridge HI and the ten-seed ensembles of PGIB and PGIB-KF on the official test engines are used; the margin added to the predicted RUL is the 5% or 10% quantile of the residuals (true minus predicted RUL) of the method, estimated on four of five folds of engines and applied to the fifth (20 repetitions), so that about this fraction of the engines fails; intervals are bootstrap intervals over engines (400 replicates). *End-to-end predictor.* Gradient boosting with the settings of the engines on the regime-normalised level and slope (windows of 10 and 30 cycles) of the 14 sensors and the age, trained on all cycles of all training engines and evaluated at the last cycle of each test engine; the information lower bound uses the lifetime distribution of the training engines. *Inclusion rule.* For Tongji, cells that never fall below 80% of the nominal capacity are kept with the last recorded cycle as end of life if at least 100 cycles were recorded.

Number of units. For each size k (5, 10, 20, 40, 80 and 120, as far as k does not exceed 80% of the units), 10 random subsets of k units were drawn without replacement; on each subset the unit-grouped cross-validation (five folds; leave-one-unit-out for $k = 5$) of Section 5 was repeated with the age-only predictor and the ridge HI, and the lower bounds were computed with the conditional entropy re-estimated from the training units of each fold. A subset is valid when the gain in the information lower bound exceeds 0.1 nat and the age-only information lower bound is at most 0.05 nat. The scripts are `fleet_size_curve.py` and `fleet_size_battery.py`.

Template shrinkage. The template is the mean ridge HI at each cycle over the training engines of the fold, and the noise standard deviation is $\sigma_2 = \Delta m/(\sqrt{2}\cdot 1.645)$ with Δm the mean template increment over the first half of the median lifetime. Mon_∞ is predicted as the mean of $2\Phi_{\mathcal{N}}(\Delta m_k/(\sqrt{2}\sigma_2)) - 1$ over the template increments Δm_k up to the median lifetime, where $\Phi_{\mathcal{N}}$ is the standard normal distribution function. Because the template slope varies along life, the predicted limit is lower than for a constant slope.

Stages. Level and velocity are the summaries of the out-of-fold ridge HI, standardised over all pairs; the target is the RUL. Stages are bins of the life fraction (0.2 to 1, edges $0.2, 0.35, 0.5, 0.65, 0.8$; oracle stages) or equal-count bins of the age (observable stages). Within a stage, the free direction is the linear least-squares fit on both features, level-only and velocity-only use one feature, and a static direction (grid of $5°$) is a fixed combination of the two features with a stage-specific affine map; the static direction minimises the sum of the out-of-fold MSEs over stages. Figure 4(c) gives the worst-stage RMSE ratio to the direction chosen separately at each stage.

Official test engines. The information lower bound uses the observed cycles of each test engine as its age, the lifetime distribution of the training engines, and the predictions of the methods of Section 6 (ten-seed ensembles for the learned encoders); the age-only baseline is the control. It assumes that the test truncation is independent of the lifetime, which the control checks.

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